



தமிழ்நாடு அரசு
தலைமைச் செயலகம்

Days of Governance



A Government for Generations

- | | | |
|--|---|---|
| Singapenn Special Task Force for Women Safety | Special Task Force for Interdiction of Narcotics and Gangs (STING) - 65 Special Task Force constituted to combat drug trafficking | 200 units of free electricity for domestic consumers using upto 500 units of electricity every 2 months |
| Thaaimaaman Thanga Mothiram Scheme Every newborn delivered in Government Hospital will receive 1 gram gold ring Rs.560 crore allocated | Annan's Seer Scheme Women will be provided with 8 gram gold coin and a silk saree for their marriage Rs.812 crore allocated | Expansion of Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Breakfast Scheme - Benefitting 15.14 lakhs additional students in Classes 6-8 across 15,414 Government and Government-aided schools. Rs.710 crore allocated |
| Vettri Tamil Nadu Investment Conclave 2026 Rs. 1 lakh crore investment | Special Incentive Sugarcane - Rs.4,000 per tonne Paddy - Rs.2,750 per quintal | Rs.6,000 crore crop loan waiver for farmers |
| 717 liquor shops located near educational institutions, temples and bus stands have been closed | Vettri Housing Scheme Rs.3,500 crore allocated | Vettri Laptop Scheme for college students Rs.2,000 crore allocated |
| Vettri Skill Training Scheme Skill Development Training for 12 lakh students and 1 lakh youth | Vettri 150 Scheme 150 days of guaranteed employment | Modern Branded bicycles with helmets and water bottles to Class XI students in Government and Government-aided schools |
| TN-VETTRI : Rs.6,000 crore allocated annually to improve Water Supply, Solid Waste Management, Sanitation and Rural Connectivity | Vettri Magalir Goat Rearing Scheme 5 goats or sheep will be provided to disadvantaged women & transgenders | Honest & Transparent governance Speedy Plan Approval, Faceless Property Registration |

Signature of the Director, Information and Public Relations Department

009/704/0524/7/2026



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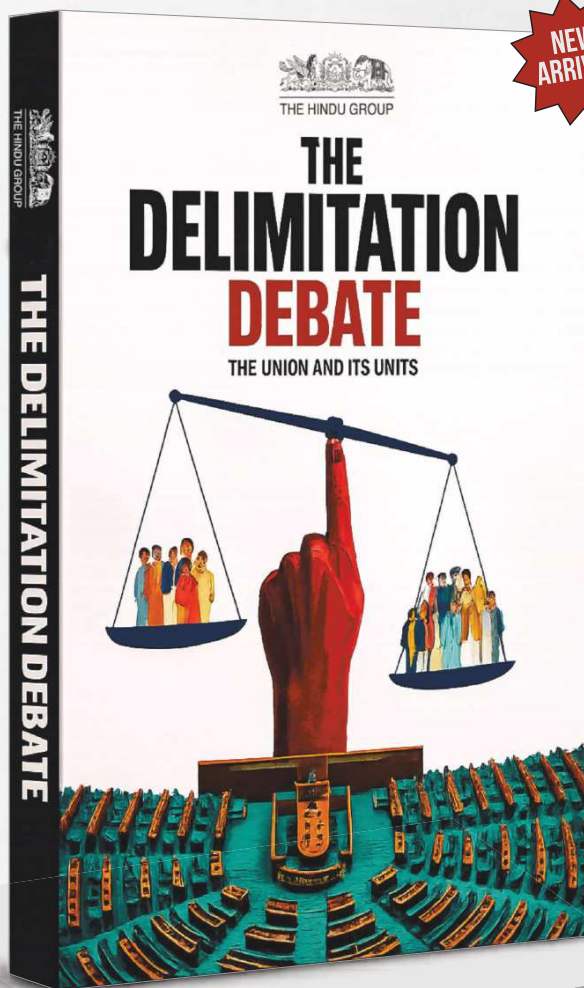
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NATIONAL SONG ROW
Amit Shah demands apology from Cong.
NEWS » PAGE 13



PHASE 2 FROM TODAY
No private data sought for Census, says official
NEWS » PAGE 12



CONTENTIOUS BILL
Sri Lanka moves to expand judges' tenure
WORLD » PAGE 16

IN BRIEF

Ex-Minister found dead in Trinamool office; row erupts

KOLKATA
Former Bengal Minister and Trinamool Congress leader Asish Banerjee was found dead on Sunday inside a party office near his residence in Birbhum district. The death triggered a political blame game, with rival TMC factions and the BJP trading allegations. » **Page 6**

JNU V-C: have become target of vicious campaign

NEW DELHI
JNU V-C Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit on Sunday rejected allegations of lapses in the hiring of teachers and called out a "vicious campaign" against her. » **Page 4**

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5 & 19

Soren govt. extends invite to protesters for discussion today

Amit Bhehari
PATNA
Protesting students burnt the effigies of Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on the 23rd day of their stir at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in Ranchi on Sunday, alleging that the State government was not serious about their demand for a Central Bureau of Investigation probe into alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs.
The Congress is a part of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM)-led government in the State.
Later in the day, the

State government extended an invitation to the protest leaders for a fourth round of talks in Ranchi on Monday afternoon, according to a district official.
Anti-govt. slogans
Beyond Ranchi, effigies were also burnt in other districts, with students shouting slogans against the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha-led government and against the Congress, which had reportedly promised to withdraw support to the State government if it did not address their demands by Independence Day.
CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

'Dimagi Naxal' doesn't mean Opposition, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI
A political row has erupted over Prime Minister Narendra Modi's reference to "dimagi [intellectual] Naxals" in his Independence Day address, with Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju clarifying on Sunday that the remark was not aimed at Opposition leaders. Mr. Modi did not say Opposition leaders are "dimagi Naxals", Mr. Rijiju said, noting that the Prime Minister was calling out those who "support Maoists and reject the Indian Constitution".
FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 13

Armed forces to provide CAPFs with list of retiring Agniveers eligible for recruitment

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI
The armed forces are likely to compile a list of Agniveers eligible for recruitment into the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) under the government's reservation policy for the temporary recruits, a government source has told *The Hindu*.
The first batch of around 25,000 Agniveers is scheduled to retire from the Army by December.
The source added that while the CAPFs, such as the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), and Assam Rifles, have reserved 50% of constable vacancies for former Agniveers, the



whereas those in the armed forces retire much earlier. "During deliberations, it was felt that, if given a choice, many Agniveers would prefer to join the CAPFs rather than continue in the armed forces because of the longer career span and greater job security," the source said.
"Therefore, it has been decided, at least initially, that the armed forces, beginning with the Army, which will witness the first batch of Agniveers retiring later this year, will provide the CAPFs with a list of eligible candidates for recruitment under the reserved quota," the source added.
The official said that the existing quotas for the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes will continue to apply for recruitment in the CAPFs.
The service tenure of personnel in the CAPFs extends up to the age of 60,
CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

With this move, retired Agniveers may not be able to directly apply for postings in the Central Armed Police Forces. FILE PHOTO

Army, Navy, and Air Force will furnish the details of eligible personnel, indicating that ex-Agniveers may not be able to apply directly for recruitment under the reserved quota.

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100 DAYS OF BHOROSHA



A
New Chapter Begins
in West Bengal



Shilpo | Swastho | Siksha | Sushashon
Shoshoktikoron | Seva | Suraksha | Samriddhi



100 DAYS

PORIBORTON AT A GLANCE

» 100 DAYS OF SHILPO

- ₹54,000+ crore worth investment proposals
- ₹5,000 crore Investment Promotion Framework
- Single-window clearance for investments above ₹100 crore
- ₹100 crore Startup Fund to encourage new ventures and young entrepreneurs

» 100 DAYS OF SUSHASHON

- Anti-Goonda Act brought into force
- Janatar Darbar brings people's grievances directly to the Chief Minister
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam implemented across the State
- Toll-free helpline to report bribery, extortion, illegal toll booths and illicit liquor trade

» 100 DAYS OF SURAKSHA

- 1,000+ acres transferred to the BSF to strengthen border security
- Durga Suraksha Squads and Pink Patrols patrolling streets to ensure women's safety
- Cyber Help Desks in every police station to combat cyber fraud
- Women's Police Stations in every subdivision and Women's Help Centres in every police station

» 100 DAYS OF SAMRIDDHI

- West Bengal's first Atal Incubation Centre (AIC Techno) launched in Kolkata, to nurture young entrepreneurs and startups
- Transparent OBC reservation frame work ensures the annulment of the unlawful 17% reservation and ensuring a fair 7% reservation
- 2 crore+ trees already planted across the state under the Ekti Gaach Mayer Namey initiative
- New airports to come up in Purulia, Balurghat and Malda, with a second greenfield airport underway in Kalyani

» 100 DAYS OF SWASTHO

- Free treatment up to ₹5 lakh under the Mukhyamantri Swasthya Yojana
- 1.43 crore families covered under Ayushman Bharat
- 2,000-bed state-of-the-art hospital coming up in New Town, with 1,000 beds reserved for the underprivileged
- AIIMS and a state-of-the-art cancer hospital in North Bengal, along with modern state-run hospitals in the Sundarbans and Jangalmahal

» 100 DAYS OF SHOSHOKTIKORON

- ₹3,000 monthly credited to the bank accounts of 1.19 crore Annapurna beneficiaries
- Free travel for women on government buses
- To secure the future of the youth, work has already commenced for creating 1 lakh government jobs by the next year
- 33% reservation for women announced in government jobs

» 100 DAYS OF SIKSHA

- Higher Mid-Day Meal allocation and improved food quality in collaboration with ISKCON
- Nearly 35,000 books from libraries across West Bengal made easily accessible online
- ₹296 crore financial assistance to improve government and Bengali-medium schools
- Sanitary napkin vending machines installed in government schools; 10 lakh+ girl students covered under Kanyaratna

» 100 DAYS OF SEVA

- ₹60,000 provided to 10.20 lakh beneficiaries under Awas Yojana
- Fish and rice now served at Maa Ahar canteens
- ₹500 increase in monthly pensions for senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities
- Daily food allocation for patients in government hospitals increased from ₹56 to ₹110



DAYS OF BHOROSHA

A commitment to development.
A vision for a prosperous West Bengal.

**NEW GOVERNMENT | NEW DIRECTION
NEW WEST BENGAL**

MCD sanitation worker killed; waste collection vehicles to stay off roads

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) Safai Karamchari Union on Sunday said it will keep the small garbage collection vehicles, called auto-tippers, off the roads from Monday following the killing of a sanitation worker, identified as Anil Kumar, in east Delhi's Kalyanpuri.

The union leaders said they will meet MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar on Monday to seek a permanent job for a member of Anil's family and an ex gratia payment of ₹1 crore, and threatened a larger protest if their demands are not met.

The 27-year-old sanitation worker was stabbed to death around 8.15 a.m. on Sunday, the police said. The attack was captured on CCTV footage, which showed a man in a yellow T-shirt approaching Anil from behind, grabbing him by the collar and repeatedly stabbing him before walking away, according to the police.

The victim was rushed to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital, where he later succumbed to his injuries. His relatives and local residents subsequently staged a protest at the hospital, demanding action against the accused. His family has alleged that the police initially informed them that Anil had met with an accident. However, on reaching the spot, they noticed the stab marks on Anil's

Leaders of the MCD Safai Karamchari Union have demanded a permanent job for the deceased's kin and ex gratia of ₹1 cr.

body. A family member said Anil had no known enemy with anyone. Deputy Commissioner of Police (East) Rajeev Kumar said the accused has been identified. "An FIR has been registered under relevant sections and efforts are under way to arrest him," he said.

The MCD said it would ensure compensation to the victim's family, adding that one of its representatives had visited the family to convey the assurance.

Kuldeep Kumar of the Aam Aadmi Party, the local MLA, met the family members and demanded compensation for them. "Does a poor man's life hold no value in this world?" he said, alleging that criminals had become emboldened under the BJP rule and urged the government to take prompt action against the accused.

'Not the first time'
"This is not the first time a sanitation worker has been beaten or killed. Violence against sanitation workers is common. Action must be taken against those responsible," said union president Karan Singh Mahroliya. He alleged that Anil had been called to duty on Sunday, an off day for him.

25 new Atal Canteens opened; 1 lakh people to get ₹5 meals daily

Setting up 100 such canteens a major milestone for my govt., says CM; facilities dedicated to the memory of Vajpayee on his death anniversary

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, along with former Vice-President M. Venkaiah Naidu, inaugurated 25 Atal Canteens on Sunday, the death anniversary of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Delhi now has 100 such canteens, where meals are served twice a day for ₹5.

Each Atal Canteen aims to provide around 1,000 meals a day. Over one lakh people will now receive meals daily from the canteens, the Delhi government said.

Addressing an event at the Vishwavidyalaya metro station, Ms. Gupta said achieving the target of 100 Atal Canteens was a major milestone for her government. "This initiative is a tribute dedicated to the spirit of Antyodaya and the ideals of public service upheld by revered Atalji. Atalji's life was devoted to the welfare of the person standing at the last mile of society and to the service of the nation. Carrying forward those very values, the Delhi government is striving to ensure that no needy person is deprived of nutritious food," the CM said.

She added that a can-



CM Rekha Gupta paying tribute to ex-PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee at the inauguration of an Atal Canteen on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

teen has also been opened near the Delhi University metro station, which will help outstation students access nutritious and affordable food.

'Laudable initiative'

Mr. Naidu said setting up 100 Atal Canteens in Delhi was a highly commendable initiative, adding that such facilities will provide affordable and nutritious food to the poor, slum dwellers, labourers and people arriving in the national capital in search of employment.

The event was also attended by Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP Manoj Tewari, Education Minister Ashish Sood, and others.

Ahead of the 2025 Assembly election, the BJP

had promised to set up Atal Canteens in slum clusters across the city.

Till now, about 95 lakh subsidised meals have been served to the public through the scheme without any holiday, as per the Delhi government.

E-Cabinet system

At a separate event, the CM said her government is planning to implement a modern e-Cabinet system to make the entire process of Delhi government Cabinet meetings paperless, more secure, faster, and more transparent.

Ms. Gupta recently held a detailed discussion with experts from the National Informatics Centre on the issue, a release stated.

Have become target of a vicious campaign by JNUSU, JNUTA: V-C

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Jawaharlal Nehru University Vice-Chancellor Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit on Sunday rejected allegations levelled by the JNU Students' Union (JNUSU) and the JNU Teachers' Association (JNUTA) regarding "irregularities" in the recruitment of teachers at the university. Responding strongly to the demands for her removal, Ms. Dhulipudi issued a statement, calling out the "malicious campaign" and "propaganda" against her.

SC/ST/OBC candidates

"Sections of the media have been running a fake malicious campaign through false, distorted, selective, or unsubstantiated narratives against me. Despite the most transparent, record recruitments, especially of the SC/ST and the OBC, in the university in the last four and a half years of my term as the V-C, I have been made the target of a vicious campaign by the JNUSU and JNUTA. No evidence, only fake propaganda," read the statement.

On August 13, the students' and teachers' union had demanded her resignation, claiming that rules regarding appointments, promotions and housing allotments were applied "arbitrarily" based on personal or "political-ideological affiliations" rather than on merit or standardised interview norms. The JNU-



JNU V-C Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit rejected the allegations regarding lapses in teachers' hirings. FILE PHOTO

SU had claimed that an investigation based on RTI responses, official records, and Executive Council dissent notes had found that at least seven faculty members were appointed in violation of UGC norms.

'Left-leaning figures'

In a separate release, the JNU administration referred to a media report on the issue, calling it a "malicious campaign by disgruntled left-leaning JNU-TA figures based on selective interpretation of UGC Regulations and JNU practices".

The administration claimed that since February 2022, the university had conducted over 400 interviews and filled over 200 positions, the "largest in its history". "A vast majority of them (nearly 70%) belong to various reserved and marginalised categories. No complaint has been received from any candidate regarding the interviews," added the university's statement.

AAP seeks L-G meeting over 'scams' by BJP government

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) legislator Sanjeev Jha on Sunday wrote to Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu seeking a thorough investigation into alleged scams committed by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in procurement of bicycles, medicines, and rice.

On August 12, the BJP had rejected the allegations as "baseless" and claimed that AAP was "rattled" by the government's welfare schemes.

In a post on X, Mr. Jha said: "I have written a letter to the Hon'ble Lt. Governor of Delhi providing detailed information, documents, and other important facts related to the serious cases of the bicycle scam, medicine scam, and rice scam, and have urged him to ensure a fair and thorough investigation into these matters."

He said it is important that the facts related to these cases come to light and appropriate action is taken against the guilty.

"On any serious issue concerning the interests of the people of Delhi, AAP and the Opposition will fulfill their responsibility with full strength," he said.

In the letter, Mr. Jha stated that a team of all Opposition MLAs, along with AAP Delhi president Saubh Bhargava, wanted to meet the L-G to present all available information and documents on the matter.

HC to hear today CBI's challenge to Kejriwal's discharge in excise case

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) plea challenging a trial court order discharging Aam Aadmi Party leaders Arvind Kejri-

wal, Manish Sisodia, and 21 others in the liquor policy case. The court is also expected to take up applications by the former Chief Minister and his former deputy seeking dismissal of the CBI's revision petition. Mr. Kejriwal and Mr. Sisodia have challenged the

maintainability of the revision petition, saying they have been unable to discern the agency's case against them.

On February 27, the trial court had discharged the 22 accused, stating that the case was "wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny".

Nearly 67% of SIR forms digitised; 45 lakh likely to be excluded

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Nearly 67% of the enumeration forms distributed to Delhi's 1.45 crore electors under the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls have been digitised by Sunday evening, according to the latest status report issued

by the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office a day before the house-to-house enumeration exercise is scheduled to end.

This means more than 45 lakh electors are likely to be excluded from the draft roll. Electors identified as absent or shifted will have to file applications during the claims and

objections period to have their names included in the final roll set to be published on October 27.

According to the report, 97,20,289 (97.20 lakh) enumeration forms, or 66.99% of the 1,45,10,299 electors, have been digitised as of 8 p.m. on Sunday. The house-to-house enumeration and digitisa-

tion exercise, which began on June 30, is scheduled to end on Monday.

District-wise, Outer North recorded the highest rate of digitisation at 75.66%, with nearly 6.30 lakh forms digitised, followed by West at 73.17% (10.65 lakh) and South West at 73.03% (9.71 lakh). North West recorded

70.83% digitisation (9.04 lakh forms), while North East stood at 70.79% (3.24 lakh). Central North had digitised 68.74% of its forms, followed by Old Delhi at 66.50%. New Delhi recorded 60.68% digitisation and South 61.05%, while South East recorded the lowest rate at 55.94%, with 8.71 lakh forms digitised.

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States

IN BRIEF



Order NIA probe into attack on Badal: Harsimrat to Shah

Shiromani Akali Dal MP Harsimrat Kaur Badal on Sunday wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah seeking a National Investigation Agency (NIA) probe into the August 13 attack on party chief Sukhbir Singh Badal and an assassination attempt on him at the Golden Temple in December 2024. Ms. Kaur, who is Mr. Badal's wife, described the August 13 incident in Maharashtra's Nanded as a "dastardly and heinous assassination bid". The two assassination attempts had "several disturbing parallels", the former Union Minister stated in her letter to Mr. Shah. **PH**

Residents seek FDA probe over 'rat in ice cream crate'

Residents of Kalyan's Godrej Hill area have asked the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to inspect a quick-commerce delivery hub in the area after a video recording surfaced purportedly showing a "rat inside an ice cream crate" at the facility. The residents sought legal proceedings against the facility for violating food safety regulations. The incident follows a recent FDA action in Malad (West), Mumbai. On August 7, food safety officers had inspected a facility at Sarvodaya Bhavan in Ramchandra Lane and found several violations, including the absence of insect and rodent control measures.

Political row erupts in Bengal after ex-Minister found dead in TMC office

Not involved in graft, attempts being made to malign image, states purported note found by police; time to reflect on human cost of political hostility: Mamata; call records should be examined: CM

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Former West Bengal Minister and Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Ashish Banerjee was found dead on Sunday morning inside a party office near his residence in Birbhum district.

The death triggered a political blame game, with rival TMC factions and the BJP trading allegations over the circumstances surrounding his death.

The 75-year-old leader, who served as a Minister in the former TMC government led by Mamata Banerjee, was a five-term party legislator from Rampurhat and Deputy Speaker of the Assembly from 2021 to 2026. He lost this year's Assembly poll to BJP's Dhruva Saha.

'Regret joining politics'

A purported note was found and the body was sent for autopsy, the police said. Ashish, who had



Ashish Banerjee

taught at Rampurhat College, was known as a leader with a clean image. The note purportedly stated that he was not involved in any "wrongdoing". The TMC leader was apparently referring to supposed allegations of wrongdoings related to the Tarapith Rampurhat Development Authority where he had served as chairperson.

"I had nothing to do with corruption and yet all these completely false allegations to malign me..." the note read, adding that he

rued becoming associated with politics and urged his children not to do so.

Leaders across political lines expressed grief over the demise of the leader.

Blame game

Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari described Ashish as a "decent political leader" and said he spoke to the former MLA's family members and asked them to cooperate with the police.

"Corrupt individuals from the Trinamool might try to intimidate them... Call records should be examined," he said.

However, Ms. Mamata, former Chief Minister and TMC chairperson, said she felt deeply disturbed over the demise. In a social media post, she stated: "Despite the work he did, he was repeatedly maligned, falsely accused and subjected to relentless pressure." While referring to the alleged harassment and mental pressure faced by Ashish, she said it

"should make all of us pause and reflect on the human cost of relentless political hostility".

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee alleged that the BJP and sections of the media should reflect on the consequences of a politics in which allegations are amplified, and reputations are put on trial before the truth is established.

Ashish had joined the camp of rebel TMC MLAs led by Leader of the Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee. Mr. Ritabrata visited the residence of the deceased leader and called him a "martyr". "He stood against the mafia syndicate of organised loot and legalised plunder, and they should be identified and punished," he said, linking Ashish's distress to alleged corruption and organisational failures during the TMC's 15-year rule.

(For those in distress, counselling is available at TeleMANAS-1446)

'Will block NHs if talks fail': mahapanchayat panel to meet CM Saini

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

A day after the police clashed in Haryana's Hansi with protesters demanding the arrest of the prime accused in the August 4 murder of dairy operative Jeevan Kundu, a mahapanchayat in Hansi on Sunday authorised a five-member panel to hold talks with Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini over their demands. The committee subsequently left for Chandigarh for talks.

The mahapanchayat, which was attended by various political leaders, social activists, farmer union representatives and khatpanchayat members, warned that the Haryana-Chandigarh (NH 52) and Haryana-Delhi (NH 9) national highways would be blocked indefinitely if the talks failed to yield a satisfactory outcome.

The protesters have made four key demands — immediate arrest of the prime accused in Kundu's murder, a government job for the deceased's wife, financial assistance for his kin, and withdrawal of the cases registered by Hansi Police against farmers and their leaders.



The mahapanchayat under way in Hansi, Haryana, on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Addressing the gathering, All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) national treasurer Krishna Prasad criticised the CM and said the State government could face "serious consequences" if the main accused is not arrested within 24 hours.

Meanwhile, 10 protesters, including five AIKS office-bearers, were produced before a court in Hansi on Sunday, which remanded them in judicial custody for 14 days.

Former Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda condemned the police action against the farmers. Sirsa MP and Congress general secretary Kumari Selja demanded an investigation into Saturday's police action.

Bihar turning into capital of paper leaks: Tejashwi; Oppn. to stage stir

Press Trust of India
PATNA

Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) national working president Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday hit out at the National Democratic Alliance government over "deteriorating" law and order in Bihar and alleged that the State is "turning into the capital of exam paper leaks".

The Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly said competitive exams were being "marred by irregularities and paper leaks".

Mahagathbandhan alliance partners will submit memorandum to Governor over 'use of AK-47 on students'

"When students protest against exam paper leaks, they are beaten and lathi-charged. Even AK-47 rifles are used against them," Mr. Yadav alleged.

The RJD leader said constituents of the Opposition Mahagathbandhan alliance will organise a march to

Lok Bhavan in Patna on August 19 and submit a memorandum to the Governor over the alleged use of an AK-47 by the police during a student protest in Siwan last month.

Pappu Yadav on fast Meanwhile, Independent MP Pappu Yadav sat on a hunger strike at a protest site in Patna on Sunday over alleged irregularities in the 70th Bihar Public Service Commission exam. He said the exam should be scrapped and held afresh.

Will protect farmers, says Karnataka CM

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

While emphasising that it was his duty to protect farmers' interests over the Cauvery water issue, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday said it is equally important to uphold the law.

Speaking at Bhagamandala in Kodagu district, Mr. Shivakumar pointed out that the reservoirs in the State were still not completely full. Along with the challenge of sustaining

farmers, there is a need to uphold the law, he said.

'Separate rules'

The Chief Minister said there were separate rules for water-sharing during periods of shortage and distress, and claimed that the Cauvery Water Management Authority had also issued the necessary directions in this regard.

"If we do not follow the law, we may end up in a situation where control of the dam has to be handed over to the Centre," he said.

Akhilesh uses AI video to hit out at BJP over 'stolen temple donations'

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday continued his attack on the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Uttar Pradesh over the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, sharing a three-minute AI-generated video on X in which people reject offers of "stolen" money.

The X post was a reaction to reports that the State government is likely

to announce an assistance of ₹20,000 for women.

Mr. Yadav urged U.P. residents to vote out the ruling party in the Assembly election due next year.

'False promises'

"The BJP has nothing left to win the election except money. Women in Uttar Pradesh say that in other States where they [BJP] won elections by promising money, they are either refusing to pay up or demanding its return," the SP president alleged.

"The BJP government could have provided ₹50,000 to women every year, but it didn't. The CM [Yogi Adityanath] has tricked everyone by spending thousands of crores of rupees meant for the benefit of U.P.'s women on his own publicity," he added.

Vows ₹40,000 yearly aid Mr. Yadav also reiterated his promise of providing an annual allowance of ₹40,000 to women. He said the amount would be increased every year.

SPOTLIGHT

Nikhil M. Babu

Patches of earth streaked a fluorescent greenish-yellow flank National Highway 19 that connects Kanpur Nagar and Fatehpur districts in Uttar Pradesh. Off the highway, a culvert also has yellow leaching on it. On the dirt road towards Chhiwali village in Fatehpur, the markings persist. They lead to Daya Devi's home, down a mud path.

Part of the concrete roof of 40-year-old Devi's two-room house is falling in. That's not her only problem though. The mother of two is more worried about her stomach pains and digestion.

"The doctor told me it is a liver infection. That was a month ago, and I'm still taking medicines," she says, touching her abdomen. "My stomach doesn't feel alright and I have to use the toilet about three times a day."

She also has rashes running along the length of both her hands, which she says "itch a lot". Many others in the village have similar health problems.

In the inner courtyard of Devi's house, her son works a hand pump. Fluorescent yellow water flows into a white plastic bucket.

"Yahan poora chemical hi aata hai (Here, only chemical flows), a woman outside Devi's house says.

She and Devi blame the

water for their health conditions.

In about a dozen areas of three districts of Uttar Pradesh — Fatehpur, Kanpur Dehat, and Kanpur Nagar — the groundwater has been contaminated by the chemical chromium (VI) or hexavalent chromium, as per State government data.

Over the last five years, the government has collected blood samples from people living in the affected areas. A 2025 government report on these tests reveals that 73-96% have above-permissible levels of chromium (VI).

Chromium is a naturally occurring hard greyish metal found in rocks and soil. But chromium (VI) compounds are produced by the chemical industry and are used in a wide range of applications like in electroplating and wood preservation. Hexavalent chromium is bright yellow-green and highly reactive.

Factories manufacture chromium sulphate in the area, which is used by tanning industries to make leather stronger. Kanpur and surrounding areas have had tanneries since the 19th century.

Green tribunal orders

In 2005, the U.P. Pollution Control Board identified six factories in Kanpur Dehat that were dumping polluting waste, untreated or improperly treated sludge and run-off. The units were shut down that year, as per a National Green Tribunal

Groundwater that glows yellow-green

Decades of industrial waste dumping have contaminated groundwater with hexavalent chromium across parts of three districts in Uttar Pradesh, exposing villagers to unsafe water and serious health risks



Chemical in garb of water: Fluorescent yellow water flowing into a plastic container as a boy works a hand pump at Chhiwali village in Uttar Pradesh's Fatehpur district. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

(NGT) report. In 2017, the NGT passed an order for the removal of chromium dumps in Kanpur Nagar.

While the government has been adding areas impacted by the chromium contamination to the list of places where environmental action is needed, the prompts often come only after the NGT orders.

About 15-20 years ago, the factories started sending *mitti* (sand) out to villagers in Chhiwali. "They would ask people if they wanted to fill their fields to build houses or if we needed cattle shed, and would dump the *mitti* for free. Many villagers used it to fill their land," Devi says.

"Back then, we had no idea that it was poisonous." Devi's neighbour, Puttali Pal, 60, says he filled his land using the *mitti* that the factories dumped.

"But after some time we started to notice that the skin on our buffaloes' legs was getting burnt and our children's nails were also getting affected. That is when we realised that

there was something wrong with the *mitti*, and we stopped them from supplying it," he says.

At the time, they didn't realise that the chemical was seeping into the groundwater. "About five-seven years back, we started seeing a faint yellow in the water, but we continued to drink it for about a year. Then we couldn't drink it any more. It tasted too bitter," she says.

Now, water comes home through pipelines laid by the government. "The pipelines are damaged and many times we get sewage-mixed water. We have even seen *keeda* (worm) in the supply water, and now we use it only after straining it," she says. "But when there is no supply, we are again dependent on hand pumps."

The houses in the neighbourhood have hand pumps that spew water with different intensities of the yellow-green colour. Devi's village, Chhiwali, is not part of the areas identified as chromium-affected by the government.

The earliest and largest chromium dump came up around 1976 in Rania, Kanpur Dehat, say NGT reports. As much as 62,225 metric tons of chromium waste was found there. It was removed only about a year ago, following NGT orders and missed deadlines. There are still patches of yellow-green at the site.

There is an NGT direction to erect a boundary wall around it to minimise the dust from flying out, but it is open. The International Agency for Research on Cancer has classified chromium (VI) as a carcinogen when inhaled.

About 500 metres from the dump, in Shivnath Purva village, a village identified by the government as affected, Roshni Devi, 30, who has four children, still remembers the day about six years ago when she drank the water from the hand pump.

"I vomited immediately. It tasted really bad even though it was not as yellow as it is now," she says. "I never drank it again. Now, even petrol will fall in front of it," she says. Her father, who is visiting, is washing his clothes with the waste-ridden water from the hand pump. "We use water from our relatives' borewell, which is deeper, for drinking. But we still use this water for washing and bathing," she says.

Raj Kumar Yadav, 50, says the government should at least supply safe piped drinking water to the village. His house was also built with chemical-laden soil from the factory. Pointing to the faint yellow tint on the walls, he says, "If you wash it, the water will still be yellow even after all these years."

While Yadav pays ₹20 every day to buy a 20-litre bottle of RO water, many labourers who work in the factories nearby are not able to afford that. "We

drink water directly from hand pumps," says Rajesh Kumar, 42, who earns ₹10,400 a month working at a factory manufacturing railway coaches.

"If you keep the water for a while, it turns light yellow. I can drink it as we are used to it. But anyone from the city won't be able to drink it," he says.

'Rise in patients'

Dr. Anurag Sachan, who runs a hospital in Aung village, Fatehpur district, says he gets 15-20 patients a month from the villages with contaminated water, many more compared to other areas.

He says over the last 10 years the number of patients coming to see him with skin and gastro issues has more than doubled.

Manoj Kumar Tiwari, Associate Professor at IIT Kanpur, who is heading a team that the government has roped in to do a comprehensive study to map the affected areas in the three districts, says cleaning up the affected areas is not an easy task.

The study has just started and the first phase of mapping areas is expected to take six months.

He says if contamination is stopped, groundwater in the aquifers can purify itself, but it can take tens to hundreds of years, depending on the nature of the aquifer and level of contamination.

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States

IN BRIEF



CJI, BCI chief must not attend convocation: NLSIU students

Students and alumni of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, have opposed the participation of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Manan Kumar Mishra, Chairman of the Bar Council of India, at their convocation. "We stand in solidarity with the NALSAR [University of Law, Hyderabad] in their request to reconsider the choice as the chief guest and express strong disapproval of the CJI attending the convocation of NLSIU," an open letter stated.

Arunachal engineering student found dead in Kerala

A 20-year-old B.Tech. student from Arunachal Pradesh, Michi Marpu, was found dead at his rented house at Kothamangalam in Kerala, on Saturday, triggering a probe. He was a third-year student at the Mar Athanasius College of Engineering. A section of students said he was upset over the "year break system", under which only those who scored 22 credits in Semester 4 could move to the next semester. (People in distress can contact Tele MANAS: 14416)

BJP's P.C. George retracts election fund misuse charge

BJP leader P. C. George, who had alleged that a large portion of the election funds for the party's campaign in Poonjar constituency in Kerala had been misappropriated, on Sunday withdrew the charge. Mr. George said the party leadership showed him the accounts after his speech and that he was now convinced there had been no financial irregularities. "After my speech, the party leadership showed me the accounts... I am convinced that nobody stole any money," he said.

Kin withdraw protest against sanctuary firing; bodies handed over

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

The post-mortem of the three suspected poachers killed in an alleged exchange of fire in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary at Hanur in Karnataka was conducted at the Mysore Medical College and Research Institute (MMC&RI) in Mysuru on Sunday, only after relatives and villagers withdrew their protest.

MMC&RI Dean Dr. Dakshayani confirmed that all three bodies were handed over to the families.

The families had earlier refused to give their consent for the autopsy until they received a written assurance of compensation and punitive action against the officials involved.

Meanwhile, the protest that began in Hanur on Saturday, intensified on Sunday. Several organisations joined a demonstration and tried to block the road to Malai Mahadeshwara Hills, demanding action against the forest staff involved in the shooting.

More compensation

Amid the tension, Hanur MLA Manjunath held discussions with the families of the deceased and eventually persuaded the protesters to withdraw the agitation. In addition to the ₹5 lakh compensation for each of the three families, the MLA promised an additional ₹10 lakh each from his personal funds.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said the forest staff had informed him that guns and two bags of meat of wild animals had been recovered from those killed in the shoot-out.

Omission of Vande Mataram sparks political row in Kerala

BJP says skipping it was a 'serious constitutional issue', says State has bowed to political pressure; CPI questions Cong's 'secular' credentials over full song rendition at AICC office, party-ruled States

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Vande Mataram question dominated the political debate in Kerala on Sunday, a day after the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government skipped the rendition of the National Song during the Independence Day function.

BJP State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar said the omission was a serious constitutional and legal issue. It is unacceptable for the State government to take a stand on issues related to nationalism by bowing to political pressures, he said. "Why is there a dif-



ferent approach only in Kerala when the National Anthem and National Song are part of official functions in Congress-ruled States such as Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir," he said.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin, in a post on X, said that bowing down be-

Why is there a different approach only in Kerala when the National Anthem and National Song are sung in Congress-ruled States

RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR
President, Kerala BJP

fore extremists has now become the Congress's permanent policy.

"This is not merely an incident of stopping a song, but a mark of that dynastic arrogance under which the Congress is averse to every single thing in India that this nation takes pride in," he said.

On the other hand, CPI

State secretary Binoy Swam questioned the full rendition of Vande Mataram at the AICC headquarters in Delhi and in Congress-ruled States.

"A secular party can never agree to the rendition of the full version of Vande Mataram as was done at the AICC headquarters. The Congress lacks ideological clarity and is not sure of its own politics. If all their claims as the inheritors of Gandhi and Nehru's ideology are true, they should apologise for what happened," he said.

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Mass fish deaths in T.N. river spark stir

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ennore fisherfolk in Tamil Nadu staged a demonstration as large quantities of dead fish were found floating in the Kossathalaiyar near the estuary in the early hours of Sunday.

Several species of fish and other aquatic life, including madurai, oodan, karuva, and kelathi, besides prawns and crabs, were found dead. The dead fish were seen floating on large stretches of the river.

They were also found along the banks, and near mangroves.

Describing the incident as an unprecedented disaster, the fisherfolk said the deaths could be linked to the discharge of chemical waste into the river, and voiced concern over the impact on their livelihood.

Fisherfolk from eight villages blocked the Thazhankuppam main road, alleging that no government official had visited the affected area or met them following the incident.

School owner lands in row over remarks

The Hindu Bureau
THIRISSUR

Controversy has erupted over the remarks by the owner of Dr. Raju Davis International School at Mala in Thirissur district of Kerala, after he reportedly told students who did not attend an Independence Day programme organised at the school to "go to Pakistan".

The remarks were allegedly made by school owner Raju Davis in a voice note shared in a WhatsApp

group of parents. According to the messages, students who remained absent from Independence Day celebrations were portrayed as lacking in patriotism. Mr. Davis reportedly warned that students who did not attend the programme would not be allowed to attend classes.

The issue also prompted the Students Federation of India (SFI) Mala area committee to take out a protest march to the school. Mr. Davis later expressed regret.

PDP leaders seeking insurance for hail-hit orchards detained

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Several leaders of the Opposition Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) were allegedly detained in south Kashmir's Shopian on Sunday when they made a bid to hold protests to push for a comprehensive crop insurance scheme for apple orchardists in Kashmir.

Former PDP legislator Aijaz Ahmad Mir, who was among those detained in Shopian, has been advocating for the inclusion of apples and cherries under a comprehensive crop insurance scheme. "Farmers hit by recent hailstorms and other natural calamities should be granted full compensation. Farmers need 100% subsidy on anti-hail nets to protect orchards from future weather-related losses," Mr. Mir said.

Horticulture is the mainstay of the economy in south Kashmir, with Shopian, Kulgam, and Pulwama emerging as major apple-exporting hubs. "The horticulture sector is the backbone of our economy and our farmers deserve protection, security, and

justice," Mr. Mir said.

The PDP leader was allegedly detained by the police at his residence in Zainapora. "Detaining voices will not silence the suffering of thousands of horticulturists who depend on horticulture for their livelihood. We will continue our peaceful and democratic struggle for our demands. I stand firmly with the growers of Shopian and Kashmir. Their issues deserve attention, not detention," he added.

'Facing distress'

The PDP protests came just two days after a hailstorm impacted the apple orchards of Shopian and Kulgam districts.

According to the Kashmir Valley Fruit Growers' Union, growers are facing distress due to the destruction inflicted on orchards. "For many farmers in south Kashmir, crops constitute their primary source of livelihood," said Bashir Ahmad Basheer, chairman of the union.

Meanwhile, the PDP appealed to the police to release all the detained leaders and workers of the party at the earliest.



Hard times: A farmer picking apples from a tree at an orchard in Pulwama district of south Kashmir. FILE PHOTO

'No proposal seeking green nod for Mahadayi diversion'

Rishikesh Bahadur Desai
BELAGAVI

There is no proposal before the Union government from Karnataka seeking Environmental Clearance (EC) for diversion of the Mahadayi river for various projects, the Centre recently told the Lok Sabha in reply to a question posed by an MP from Goa.

While this is being interpreted as a setback for the project by sections in Goa, officials in the know in Karnataka, however, maintain that EC is not relevant for a drinking water project.

Kirti Vardhan Singh, Union Minister of State for Environment, Forest and Climate Change, in response to a question on EC by Captain Viriato Fernandes, MP



The Centre responded to the question raised by a Goa MP.

from South Goa, said that no proposal seeking an EC for any river diversion project involving the Mahadayi river is presently under consideration in the ministry.

The reply further said that the National Board for Wildlife (NBWL) has not approved Karnataka's proposal to use 10,6852 hec-

tares of forest land for the Kalasa Nala Diversion Scheme in the tiger corridor between the Kali and Sahyadri Tiger Reserves.

The Minister said that no proposal or river basin details for conducting a Cumulative Impact Assessment (CIA) and Carrying Capacity Study (CCS) of the Mahadayi basin have been submitted by the State governments concerned.

In his question, the MP had highlighted concerns voiced by civil society groups, scientific institutions and experts regarding the proposed diversion of the Mahadayi, claiming that it could affect Goa's drinking water security, lead to potential saline ingress and freshwater aquifers in the river basin.

Roaring start



Festival frenzy: Artists performing 'Pulikali' (tiger dance) during the 'Athachamayam' procession, which marks the start of the 10-day Onam celebrations, at Tripunithura in Ernakulam district of Kerala on Sunday. THULASI KAKKAT

38-year-old woman, son held for killing two for gold in Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A 38-year-old woman and her minor son have been arrested in Siddipet district of Telangana for allegedly murdering at least two women for gold.

The police on Sunday said the woman, Chakali Rajitha, told them during questioning that she watched crime fiction and videos online to learn methods of murder and disposal of bodies.

On August 8, villagers of Ramakkapeta spotted a partially burnt body near agricultural fields. The Dubbak police registered a case and later identified the victim as a woman named Athikam Vijaya, 45,

Investigation revealed that the accused had identified three more women as targets

a resident of Bhoompally village.

Close watch

Siddipet Police Commissioner Rashmi Perumal said the police used CCTV footage to identify the killers as a woman from Bhoompally and her teenaged son, who together ran a tea point. They targeted women who could be robbed and used their outfit to observe people and gather information.

The police said that on

May 28, the duo murdered another woman, Kunta Rekha, and burnt her body in the Achamayapalli forest area. The investigation further revealed that the accused had allegedly identified three more women as targets.

The police alleged that the woman had earlier planned to kill her husband and had poured scalding water on his feet. The police seized 5.61 tolas of gold ornaments (1 tola is 146 sovereigns), 53 tolas of silver ornaments, ₹1.03 lakh in cash, two mobile phones, and a moped which was allegedly used to transport the dead bodies. The total value of the seized property was estimated at around ₹10 lakh.

MSC Elsa 3 sinking caused no significant impact on Lakshadweep islands: study

G. Krishnakumar
KOCHI

A comprehensive assessment carried out by the Chennai-based National Centre for Sustainable Coastal Management on the potential environmental impact on the Lakshadweep islands following the sinking of the container vessel MSC Elsa 3 off the Kerala coast on May 25, 2025 has found that the shipwreck did not result in measurable ecological or socioeconomic damage to the archipelago.

However, the incident has underscored the inherent vulnerability of remote island ecosystems to maritime accidents and highlighted the impor-



MSC Elsa 3, a container ship carrying hazardous cargo, sinking off the Kerala coast in the Arabian Sea on May 25, 2025. AP

tance of strengthening maritime incident preparedness through early warning systems, island-specific contingency planning, coordinated inter-agency response mechanisms and sustained environmental monitoring to enhance resilience against future spill risks, according to the research based on

field surveys, analysis, remote sensing, numerical trajectory modelling and stakeholder consultations.

The study was carried out as per the directives issued by the National Green Tribunal after it took suo motu cognisance of the report titled "Containers from sunken ship likely to

drift towards Alappuzha, Kollam Coasts in 48 hours: INCOIS" published in The Hindu.

A report prepared by the NSCSM on the potential environmental and socio-economic risks of the incident on the Lakshadweep islands said that multiple lines of evidence indicated that physicochemical parameters of seawater and sediments remained within the natural baseline ranges characteristic of coral atoll environments. Biological assessments confirmed the absence of stress or degradation in plankton communities, benthic assemblages, coral reefs, seagrass meadows and associated lagoonal habitats, it said.



United and free India needs unity, not uniformity; dissent must not be seen as divisive

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Independence Day speech, his thirteenth, was delivered within an entirely new political context, shaped by the recent student protests that led to the resignation of his Education Minister. The protests may have waned, but their underlying and lingering reasons for the unrest remain a matter of serious concern for the country. Mr. Modi sought to offer hope, inspiration and purpose on the one hand while, on the other, built a new phantom labelled '*dimagi* naxals', who, he said, influenced policymaking and required purging. The speech was specifically addressed to the young citizens of the nation. Mr. Modi repeatedly stressed the need for big dreams, firm resolve and rapid execution, arguing that India could no longer think in incremental terms. He promised skill training for one crore youth over the next year to prepare India for the artificial intelligence era; free online coaching for competitive examinations to reduce the burden on families and improve access to opportunities; and renewed the government's emphasis on innovation, quantum technology, space, robotics, data centres and other emerging sectors. Mr. Modi reiterated his commitment to self-reliance in defence production, including advanced technologies such as drones and next-generation defence systems. All Indians would naturally appreciate these promises and the statement of purpose.

Whether Mr. Modi wanted, or tried, to build a unified national approach towards these challenges and their management is doubtful. India's progress is a continuum that should ideally have a compounding effect with each subsequent year. Comparing, in absolute terms, achievements before and after 2014, when he became Prime Minister, is neither statistically relevant nor politically prudent. The fact about India as it enters the 80th year as a free nation that fought off colonialism is that its challenges are unprecedented. It has a massive young population entering the workforce even as technology is disrupting life and work as never before. What India needs is an all-hands-on-the-deck approach, requiring a unified political will among parties and stakeholders that is unaffected by electoral contests. India also needs an indigenous understanding and philosophy of development rather than trying to mimic the techno-capitalism that is rattling advanced economies. This is a point that was underlined by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat in his Independence Day speech. Mr. Modi clearly sees the challenges; but he also sees, unfortunately, an enemy in every critic. As he leads the country into a new year of independence, perhaps he could consider new ideas, including those from his critics, instead of amplifying divisive ones.

Not just turbulence India's aviation should not have to depend on chance for safety

The August 4, 2026, incident involving Air India flight AI 2279, from Phuket to Delhi, with 137 passengers and eight crew, now has two tracks. The first concerns its reclassification: the initial 'event of turbulence' is now a "serious incident" after inflight technical issues and a significant deviation in aircraft attitude caused injuries to more than 20 passengers and crew, quickly drawing in the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). The subsequent probe by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau, along with France's investigation authority, BEA, and technical representatives from Airbus, should unravel the multiple anomalies that briefly overtook the Airbus A320N — fault warnings across the hydraulic systems, elevator flight-control faults, autopilot disconnection, emergency-exit door indications and an engine anti-ice warning. Airbus's initial data is said to support the evidence of technical errors. However, it is the second track that has received much attention: the result of the pilot-in-command's post-flight screening for psychoactive substances.

The Tata Group Singapore Airlines joint venture airline has been prodded into commencing the immediate and mandatory screening of its flight deck crew "for any substances or unprescribed medications". But the deeply discomfiting discovery has exposed the weak link in crew screening — the greater emphasis on pre- and post-flight breathalyser checks for alcohol than on testing for psychoactive substances, which falls under the Civil Aviation Requirements (CAR) Section 5-Air Safety Series F Part V. In fact, the CAR — which applies to Air Traffic Controllers also — leans more towards random and post-flight/post-shift testing, with graded disciplinary action. With India's air carriers expanding operations, crew citing stress-related issues, and, separately, the availability of substances for medicinal or recreational use, the regulator must ensure stringent psychoactive substance testing and operational compliance. The DGCA's Medical Circular No. 02 of 2021, on 'over-the-counter (OTC) drugs and self-medication', highlights pilot cognitive/psychomotor skills impairment, drawing on the Mangaluru (2010) and Kozhikode (2020) fatal air accidents. Further, documented cases from the West reveal that even small levels of impairment can affect crew judgement, reaction time, coordination, and decision-making, the critical skills needed in the flight deck. Ensuring that fit crew are behind the controls is an aviation industry bedrock, and every Indian operator, large or growing, must uphold the highest standards. This was a lucky escape, but luck cannot be allowed to become a safety strategy.

The "One Nation, One Election (ONOE)" proposal (to enforce a uniform, synchronised timeline for national and State elections across India) represents a profound misapprehension of the structural mechanics of the parliamentary system, and poses an existential threat to the federal architecture designed by the framers of the Constitution.

To align the distinct political rhythms of dozens of individual States with the central government, in the name of national uniformity, is to prioritise administrative convenience over democratic substance. The argument for synchronisation relies heavily on a superficial calculation of financial expenditure and an overblown narrative of governance paralysis. Yet, it ignores the fundamental constitutional friction that occurs when presidential mechanics are clumsily grafted onto a parliamentary democracy.

Flexibility at democracy's core

At the very heart of the parliamentary form of government is the principle that the executive branch derives its legitimacy directly from, and remains continuously accountable to, the legislature. Unlike a presidential system, where the executive is elected independently for a strict, unalterable calendar term, a parliamentary executive exists entirely at the pleasure of the legislative majority. A Prime Minister or a Chief Minister rules only as long as they command the confidence of the house. Consequently, the parliamentary system is inherently built around flexibility; terms are not rigidly fixed because the collapse of a governing coalition, a successful motion of no confidence, or a shifting legislative realignment must naturally trigger a democratic reset. That is why India's elections, which ran on the same timetable from 1952 to 1967, no longer do: governments at the State and the Centre fell at different times when they lost their legislative majorities, and were elected accordingly thereafter, leading to the current situation where some State or the other is going to the elections every year.

Imposing a fixed-term electoral calendar artificially binds the legislature, completely short-circuiting this parliamentary accountability mechanism. If a government falls, forcing a fixed timeline means that the electorate is stripped of its sovereign right to choose a new government for a full five-year mandate. Instead, the system must resort to truncated midterm Assemblies elected merely to serve out the unexpired remainder of the original calendar. This introduction of variable, short-term governance undermines the stability it claims to protect, creating weak, insecure "lame-duck" administrations whose bureaucrats, police forces and political opponents will simply run down the clock rather than engage in decisive long-term policymaking.

The alternative, of resorting to President's Rule when a State government falls, rather than



Shashi Tharoor

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The 'One Nation, One Election' proposal will erode State autonomy, distort electoral mandates, and weaken democratic accountability

holding a fresh election, is even more undemocratic. This would inevitably force a domino effect of constitutional crises that severely erodes the value of a citizen's vote. Under a synchronised system, the democratic leverage of the electorate is fundamentally distorted. A citizen voting in a midterm election to fill a two-year unexpired term is structurally handed less political bargaining power than a voter casting a ballot at the dawn of the five-year cycle. If full-term and midterm governments wield identical constitutional powers, it is a violation of democratic equity that their corresponding popular mandates carry unequal temporal weight. Furthermore, the logic of synchronisation dictates that if the national Parliament dissolves prematurely due to a fractured coalition in New Delhi, stable State legislative assemblies possessing absolute, robust majorities would be abruptly terminated by operation of law, simply to keep the national "one election" clock on course. To dissolve a functional, democratically elected State government because of a political realignment in New Delhi is a direct assault on the political sovereignty of that state's electorate, subordinating regional democratic choices to national political dynamics.

National politics will overshadow States

This subordination exposes the deeply anti-federal undercurrents of the synchronisation agenda. India is fundamentally a union of States, a vast pluralistic landscape where regional identities, local economic contexts, and historical trajectories demand distinct political expressions. Federalism is not a mere administrative arrangement; it is a vital mechanism for cultural and political accommodation.

By combining State and national elections into a single mega-event, the distinct boundaries between localised issues and national narratives are blurred. In a synchronised ballot, national parties with vast financial apparatuses and dominant media presence naturally tend to overshadow regional parties. Local grievances regarding regional infrastructure, provincial welfare, and cultural preservation risk being entirely subsumed by overarching national rhetoric or geopolitical theatre. Electorates are subtly coerced into prioritising national alignment over regional suitability, a phenomenon captured by the majoritarian push for uniform alignment under the guise of developmental efficiency. This dynamic pressures voters to instal identical parties at both the State and centre, penalising States that choose independent political paths and starving them of federal resources if they dissent from the national ruling party.

The financial justifications used to defend this centralisation of power are equally flawed. The claim that simultaneous elections will drastically cut public spending deliberately conflates the minimal, necessary administrative costs incurred

by the State with the unregulated, private campaign expenditures of political parties. The official funds spent by the Election Commission of India to manage independent cycles are a drop in the ocean for an economy of India's scale, a small and necessary price to pay for maintaining a responsive democracy. Conversely, the vast sums of money circulated by political parties during campaigns actually function as a form of informal economic redistribution, temporarily generating widespread employment and shifting capital back down to printers, local transport networks, artisans, and working-class citizens. To restrict this economic circulation to once every five years under the banner of austerity is an argument that privileges elite fiscal preferences over the periodic economic stimuli that campaigns provide to the informal sector.

Moreover, the complaint that the continuous cycle of elections creates a perpetual state of policy paralysis due to the Model Code of Conduct is an administrative myth. The electoral code is designed strictly to prevent the ruling executive from announcing opportunistic, brand-new financial handouts or executing politically-motivated bureaucratic transfers during the immediate run-up to a vote. It does not freeze the wheels of the State, nor does it halt the execution of ongoing public works, routine governance, or essential administrative duties. The narrative of paralysis is often deployed by executives to excuse structural inefficiencies that have nothing to do with the electoral calendar. In reality, the frequency of independent State elections serves as a critical check on executive hubris, forcing political representatives to regularly return to the doorsteps of their constituents with folded hands. This continuous accountability cycle keeps political parties responsive to shifting public sentiment, whereas a single, synchronised event leaves a five-year void where representatives are essentially insulated from the popular will.

Diminishing the voter's voice

Ultimately, the drive toward uniform elections is an attempt to transform the organic, messy vitality of a decentralised parliamentary democracy into the rigid, totalising efficiency of an authoritarian state model. It reduces the sovereign voter to a cog in an administrative machine, strips States of their distinct political timelines, and creates dangerous vacuums where insecure, short-term governments cannot effectively rule. By treating elections as an expensive administrative burden to be minimised rather than the primary lifeblood of public accountability, the ONOE model devalues the constitutional spirit of the republic. True democratic strength does not lie in forced conformity or synchronised clocks, but in the enduring resilience of a federal compact that allows its many distinct regions to live, breathe, and vote according to their own unique conditions.

India is losing West Asia, but it is not too late



Raja Karthikeya

Adjunct Fellow and Lead for West Asia Studies at the Takshashila Institution

West Asia is changing rapidly and India must act before its influence fades

countries is likely to directly take on Iran alongside the U.S. The pact is thus aimed less at Iran and more at deterring Israel. All three countries see themselves as the next target of Israel after Iran. They thus want to pool Saudi capital, Pakistan's military strength, and Türkiye's technological advances.

This is a challenge for India. A future war between Israel and Pakistan will inevitably draw in India given the close partnership between Israel and India. Similarly, even greater Turkish support for Pakistan in a future conflict that Pakistan might have with India cannot be ruled out.

The choices before India

What then is India's strategy? It appears to be confident of Israel's victory in its various battles in the region given its proximity to the U.S. But U.S. politics are changing rapidly, with both 'Make America Great Again' Republicans and Democratic Socialists questioning the once-unquestioned U.S. support for Israel. Can Israel then emerge triumphant alone?

India has cultivated a special relationship with the UAE given the importance of remittances from Indian expat workers in the country, the investments by the Indian elite in the UAE and the UAE's strategic investments in India. But the UAE's mounting differences with Saudi Arabia are a cause for concern, as are its positions against UN-recognised governments in conflicts as far as Sudan. Can the UAE emerge unscathed in all these conflicts?

India can choose to sign military alliances with Israel and the UAE. But this would hurt what is left of India's relationship with Iran and Saudi Arabia. India can choose to do nothing as it is doing now. And its merchant mariners may keep getting killed in the Strait of Hormuz while more Indian ships may sink in the Bab-el-Mandeb.

A great power in the making risks appearing hobbled and hobbled in its immediate maritime neighbourhood.

Or, India can pick a third way. It can devise an active regional political strategy. Re-engage the Saudis with whom it has no explicit differences.

It can start playing a role of rebuilding trust between the Arab countries and Iran, starting with the UAE-Iran relationship. It can engage in Jordan's security offering Jordan defensive technologies at a time when U.S. munitions are running low. It can engage in the future UN peacekeeping role in Lebanon, which is now under a cloud, with the forecast being an end to the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL). It can even run a back-channel with Türkiye sharing its red lines about its relationship with Pakistan. If India cannot join the new Saudi-led maritime force for the Red Sea, it can work with Egypt on a parallel effort to safeguard India-bound shipping, from the Suez Canal to Bab-el-Mandeb. It can look into setting up a military presence in the Red Sea region whether in Somaliland or Socotra. Building on current military training exchanges, it can start drills and military exercises with a range of countries in the region.

Think of bridge-building

India can also appoint a new Special Envoy for West Asia — not one focused on the Israel-Palestine peace process necessarily, but one who can draw all the threads together to secure India's interests in the region at a time of unprecedented turbulence. All of this can be part of one pro-active vision for India to support a new security architecture for West Asia — one that does not draw new battle lines but instead contributes to trust-building.

India cannot afford to be a stranger to West Asia. India has both the capacity and the responsibility to help restore peace and predictability in the region.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Political labelling

The Prime Minister often creates new terms and expressions to disparage opponents and dissenters. After previous labels such as 'urban Naxals', 'tukde-tukde gang' and 'andolanjevis' became outdated, he has used the national platform to introduce a new one:

'*dimagi* (intellectual) naxals'. This seems aimed at the student leaders behind the Gen Z protests, which have somewhat damaged his strongman image. If his warning about a 'malicious plan to harm the country' was genuine, he should have clearly outlined the traits of such individuals.

This vague label is another excuse for his government to target inconvenient voices and regain lost ground (Page 1, August 16).
Kamal Laddha, Bengaluru

True patriotism

The controversy over the rendition of the full version

of *Vande Mataram* at the headquarters of the Congress party (August 16) has emerged amid the government's emphasis on its complete rendition. Patriotism should extend beyond symbolic expressions of attachment to the nation to include a tangible commitment to the

safety, dignity and well-being of its people. Mindless violence against individuals suspected of transporting beef, or attacks on Christians at peaceful prayer meetings, are equally incompatible with the values of patriotism and constitutional democracy. The democratic ideal is not

the dominance of the majority over minorities, but a constitutional framework in which every citizen can participate with equal dignity and security.
Matthew Adukanil, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

How AI can be optimised for better healthcare

Modern medicine has built an extraordinary depth of knowledge. However, how much of that knowledge can reach the patient who needs it now? The answer has traditionally depended on the number and distribution of trained clinicians, the institutions in which they work, and the systems that connect them to patients. All three are difficult to expand quickly. For India, which is still expanding its healthcare capacity while its disease burden becomes more complex, the question of how far health expertise can reach is particularly consequential.

Here, Artificial Intelligence (AI) introduces a new dimension. It offers a way of taking the accumulated knowledge and making more of it available at the point of care. The change is visible across major health systems. In January 2025, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) said it had authorised more than 1,000 AI-enabled medical devices. These include tools used in radiology, cardiology, and other areas of diagnosis. In the U.K., the NHS issued a guidance in April 2025 for the use of AI-enabled ambient scribing. By January 2026, the country was developing a national programme to support wider adoption, with early evidence suggesting that the technology could give doctors up to a quarter more time with their patients.

These examples point to a wider change. AI is moving out of innovation teams and into consultations, diagnostic workflows, and hospital operations. The real work now lies in making it dependable enough for routine use.

The economic benefits India has its own set of challenges. Specialist care remains concentrated in larger cities, while chronic conditions require patients to be monitored over many years. Hospitals are also managing rising volumes without being able to increase clinical



Sumeeta Reddy
Managing Director,
Apollo Hospitals
Enterprise Ltd.

A January 2026 McKinsey analysis estimated that applying AI across healthcare revenue-cycle operations could reduce the cost to collect by 30% to 60%

capacity at the same pace.

An AI tool that helps prioritise a radiology scan, alerts a care team to a deteriorating patient or supports a physician handling a complex case in a smaller city can make existing capacity work more efficiently.

The country has already built much of the digital foundation required for this shift. By May 2026, more than 100 crore health records had been linked to the Ayushman Bharat Health Accounts, twice the number recorded in February 2025. A July 2026 government update reported that the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) Scan and Share service had reduced outpatient registration waits at participating hospitals from around an hour to between two and five minutes. These improvements did not require a dramatic reinvention. It came from removing friction from a familiar hospital process. AI can extend the same principle to appointment scheduling, clinical documentation, claims, inventory planning, and discharge management. Each task takes time away from care if handled poorly.

Additionally, the financial benefits from using AI is becoming harder for healthcare providers to ignore. A January 2026 McKinsey analysis estimated that applying AI across healthcare revenue-cycle operations could reduce the cost to collect by 30% to 60%. For hospitals, these gains can free resources for clinical teams, equipment and capacity. They can also reduce administrative work that contributes to staff fatigue.

There is yet another part related to the business side that receives less attention. AI can help providers offer services that were previously difficult to deliver at scale. Remote monitoring can extend care beyond discharge. Risk-based preventive programmes can identify people who need attention before symptoms become severe. Virtual specialist support can connect smaller hospitals with expertise located elsewhere. Diagnostics can

be taken closer to communities, while hospitals maintain an ongoing relationship with patients managing diabetes, cardiac disease or cancer.

Judicious use

These models create revenue, but their value does not come from selling more technology. It comes from reaching patients earlier and avoiding preventable deterioration. This is also where restraint matters. A system that performs well in one hospital or population may not work equally well across India's States, disease patterns, and care settings. Clinical validation, representative data, and human oversight also need to be seriously considered. The FDA's September 2025 call for better methods to evaluate AI-enabled devices in real-world settings reflects a concern that every health system will have to confront. The tools' performance at launch does not guarantee performance over time.

Healthcare does not need AI everywhere. It needs it where delays can be reduced, clinicians can make better-informed decisions, and more patients can receive appropriate care. As India marks another year of Independence, there is a larger dimension to this conversation. The economic strength of a nation ultimately rests on the capabilities of its people. Healthcare therefore belongs within the architecture of economic development. India has built considerable physical and digital infrastructure over the decades; the next phase of development will depend increasingly on the health, longevity and productivity of its population. AI can contribute by making expertise widely available and by shifting healthcare towards earlier detection and continuous management.

The economic return on AI in healthcare will be measured not by the number of systems deployed, but by the number of lives touched and its impact on human life and happiness.

Andhra's urban transformation

The State's municipal department is trying to build a sustainable urban model

STATE OF PLAY

V. Raghavendra

The Municipal Administration and Urban Development (MA&UD) Department of Andhra Pradesh is caught in the time warp of archaic administrative measures. But now it seems the light has dawned as it tries to catch up with the times.

A top official of the department, at the recent Green Andhra Summit organised by the Indian Green Building Council, noted in disbelief that one of the most laughable things about urban local bodies was its imposition of a 'tree guard fee'. The audience went into a fit of giggles as the official continued to say that about 45 different types of charges are being collected by the MA&UD Department. He stated that he has since sought to make systemic changes with a new sense of urgency in order to achieve sustainable development.

An overhaul

The government is streamlining a whole lot of procedures and doing away with redundant ones in keeping with the Swarna Andhra 2047 Vision.

A significant step towards transforming cities and towns into cleaner urban agglomerations is a mandate to apartment complexes, if the waste generated per day exceeds 100 kilos, to set up their own in-situ solid waste management units. This has not yet been made formally mandatory, but it is a welcome move as the government intends to rid cities and towns of waste.

To complement this move, the department contemplated giving incentives for using treated wastewater, like it is done in some advanced coun-



tries across industrial, commercial, and drinking purposes. The Reuse of Treated Used Water Policy, 2026 has been approved by the government to boost long-term water security, reduce freshwater dependence, and promote a circular water economy.

Additionally, the existing model of developing slums is being reworked to achieve the twin objectives of improving the quality of life for the slum dwellers and making cities look beautiful. Towards this, the Greater Visakhapatnam Municipal Corporation is embarking on the redevelopment of a slum on the DBFT (Design, Build, Finance and Transfer) basis under the Visakhapatnam Economic Region Program through suitable amendments to the Andhra Pradesh Building Rules of 2017. It involves the construction of a high-rise building which should accommodate 177 housing units. This is a first-of-its-kind project taken up anywhere in the State as a result of the slew of relaxations in the Floor Space Index (FSI) norms in order to make projects viable for developers in small slum areas.

A green economy The MA&UD Department has also laid greater thrust on green buildings by encouraging the use of green materials at the design stage itself as well as for necessary modifications in existing buildings; va-

rious incentives are also being planned to accelerate this adoption such as giving discounts in development charges, irrespective of the types of use (residential or commercial). The focus on green buildings is in tune with the growing need to reduce the carbon footprint of the construction sector, and in the process facilitate the unobstructed transmission of natural light and free flow of air, which makes the buildings energy-efficient and thereby economically viable.

Keeping in view the multiple benefits of green buildings, the government is extending the initiative to ordinary houses, schools, hospitals, and commercial establishments like never before. It has also stipulated hefty penalties in case of violations.

These things apart, the government has prioritised the optimisation of land use (utilising vacant private land for public spaces) and transit-oriented development to incentivise transit corridors and stops. The MA&UD has already eased the zoning regulations and reduced the number of zones from 15 to 10 for the sake of flexibility in urban development.

The whole idea, as per the MA&UD official, is to make the city grow rapidly and be adaptive, like it happened with London and Paris among other great global cities.

A decisive shift is thus underway towards deep-tech governance, fiscal self-reliance, and environmentally resilient urban living, keeping in line with the theme 'build faster and better and grow green'. This can already be seen in Amaravati, the emerging greenfield capital city of Andhra Pradesh.

raghavendra.v@thehindu.co.in

Girls conditioned from childhood to take up domestic burden

The time women spend on housework begins to rise around the age of 10 and reaches a peak of nearly 460 minutes a day around age 30

DATA POINT

Tanu M. Goyal
Mohd. Tahoor
Shravani Prakash

In a recent interaction with women aspiring to become entrepreneurs in rural Haryana, it was found that other than social and cultural norms, the biggest practical problem constraining the women's ability to do more paid work was that a large share of their time was tied up in cooking and completing household chores. Strikingly, their daughters, rather than their sons, were already sharing this burden by helping them in the kitchen and other chores. The next generation, it seemed, is already learning to reproduce the gender gap in invisible, unpaid work.

India's Time Use Survey (2025) highlights that the division of labour that emerges in adulthood begins much earlier, through childhood conditioning. What starts in childhood widens with age, reaching its peak in the prime working years (Chart 1).

The time women spend on housework begins to rise around the age of 10 and continues through the late teens and twenties, reaching a peak of nearly 460 minutes (7.5 hours +) a day around age 30. The male curve, however, never crosses 65 minutes at any age between six and 75. Adolescence, in this sense, is not separate from adulthood; it is when the adult pattern begins to take shape (Chart 1). Data shows that at age six, Indian boys and girls spend almost the same amount of time on domestic and care work at about five minutes a day (Chart 2). Their trajectories remain relatively close through early childhood. Thereafter, however, they diverge sharply.

Around age 10, the girls' curve begins to pull away. Girls spend about 15 minutes a day on domestic and care work at age 10, 75 minutes at 15, and around 130 mi-

nutes by age 17. Boys, meanwhile, move from roughly five minutes at age six to only about 17 minutes by the end of childhood. The result is a dramatic widening of the gender gap. The girl-to-boy ratio in unpaid work rises from 1.6 among children aged 6-9, to 4.5 among those aged 10-14, and to 7.5 among adolescents aged 15-17.

Little control over time

The cost is leisure. Between ages six and 17, girls' housework rises by roughly 124 minutes a day, while their leisure time falls by around 115 minutes. For boys, the decline in leisure is much smaller but the time they spend on housework changes relatively little.

This matters because the cost of girls' domestic work is often framed primarily as a trade-off with schooling and education. But data shows that girls, in fact, are spending slightly more time on learning than boys at most ages. They, therefore, remain in school but still pay a substantial price in leisure time that could be spent on sport, friendships, rest, exploration and simply having discretionary control over their own time. These are not economically irrelevant activities. They are part of how children build confidence, social networks, physical capability and even a sense of agency, all of which influence their ability to build career trajectories later in life (Chart 2).

Cooking lies at the centre of this divergence (Chart 3). Among adolescents aged 15-17 years, 42.4% of girls report cooking, compared with only 2.9% of boys. Girls in this age group spend close to an hour cooking, while boys spend just two minutes. Cleaning and laundry also become increasingly gendered with wide gaps in both participation and time spent. The only tasks where adolescent boys match or exceed girls are farm work and shopping; activities that are more outward-facing (the field and market), rather than inward-facing into the kitchen.

Between childhood and adulthood, therefore, girls are being trained for the household while boys are being trained for the world outside. This helps explain why childhood conditioning can later appear as an "efficient" gendered allocation of household work.

One of the clearest manifestations of these gendered expectations is women's absence from the labour force. In the 2025 PLFS, childcare and domestic responsibilities were the single most-cited reason women gave for staying out of the labour force, reported by 52.5% of urban women and 40% of rural women, compared with less than 1% of men.

Most policy interventions address women's unpaid work in adulthood through childcare, community kitchens, safe mobility infrastructure, flexible work and social protection, among others. But the Time Use Survey suggests that policy must also start much earlier, by addressing the unequal assignment of domestic work between boys and girls.

The objective is not to remove domestic work from children's lives, but to remove its gender assignment. Schools can help by giving every child, boy or girl, equal opportunities to learn practical life skills, from cooking and home management to stitching, carpentry and financial management.

India has invested heavily in keeping girls in school and improving their educational outcomes, but equal attention must be paid to what happens to their time outside school. Otherwise, by the time young women enter the labour market, years of gendered conditioning and unpaid work may already have narrowed their choices. If we want a different workforce tomorrow, we may need to start by giving boys and girls a different childhood today.

Authors work at the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER). Views expressed are personal

Disproportionate burden

The data for the charts were sourced from India's Time Use Survey (2025) and the Ministry of Statistics and Program Implementation (MoSPI)

CHART 1: Time spent on housework (unpaid domestic and caregiving services)

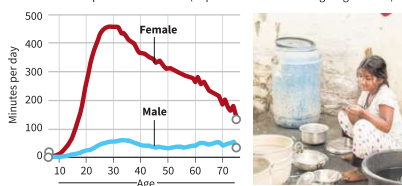


CHART 2: Time spent by children on domestic work, leisure and learning

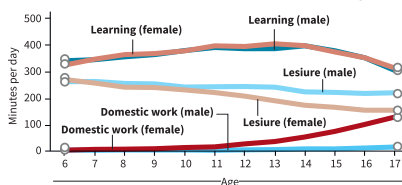
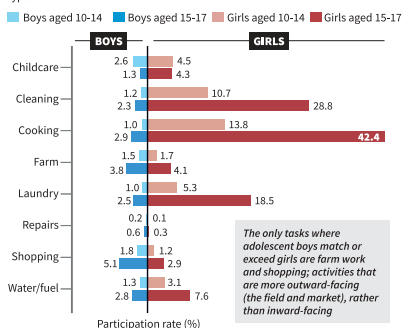


CHART 3: The share (participation rate) of girls and boys who engage in different types of housework



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 17, 1976

Water supplies dry up in U.K.

London, August 16: The possibility that Britain, an island normally drenched by Atlantic rains, may have to import drinking water is now being seriously studied by planners, according to informed sources.

With no sign of a let-up in the country's worst drought since 1727 when records started officials recognise that such drastic action as importing water by ship from Scandinavia and distributing it by tanker lorries may become necessary.

Water supplies are rapidly drying up and a million homes in South Wales already have water cut off at night. From next month, people in parts of Western England will have to queue at Stand-pipes for supplies.

Strict rationing starts in the Channel Island of Jersey to-day and has been in force in neighbouring Guernsey island since a state of emergency was declared in June. Without such measures water would run out in six weeks.

After reveling an untypically dry and glorious summer, Britons are now waking up to the prospect that if the rains stay away through the autumn they could be in for a winter of hardship with food and industrial production hit.

All 10 water authorities in England and Wales have promptly told the Government that they will be applying to use powers made available under the Drought Act. Three authorities covering North-East, South, West and the whole of Wales are demanding the right to cut off water to homes whenever they wish.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 17, 1926

Manchester cotton trade

London, August 16: The Federation of Master Cotton Spinners Association has inaugurated a scheme for the protection of American Spinning Scheme of the trade from undercut selling. "Basic prices" which are in effect minimum prices, are fixed for a standard quality of American cotton and beams. Salesmen of the Manchester Exchange representing firms producing these yarns have been instructed to quote prices coinciding with the Federation's list. The elimination of cheap sellers seems only a matter of time if the Federation members stand together. The Federation and Non-Federation concerns have promised loyal support.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Area affected by Belgium wildfire since Friday

3,000 in hectares. A wildfire raging in a nature reserve in eastern Belgium, the biggest to hit the country in recent history, has more than doubled in size in 24 hours to affect some 3,000 hectares, authorities said on Sunday. The Wallonia regional government said that over 250 emergency personnel were mobilised. *AFP*

Persons killed in Israeli strikes in southern Lebanon

11 Israel vowed on Sunday it would hit Hezbollah again if threatened, as it identified what it described as a commander killed in strikes a day earlier that also left several children dead. Israeli strikes on Saturday killed 11 people in southern Lebanon, according to authorities, in the deadliest attacks since a deal was reached in June aimed at ending hostilities. *AFP*

Roads blocked in Himachal Pradesh due to torrential rains

118 Torrential rains in Himachal Pradesh have led to the closure of 118 roads across the State, as the local meteorological office issued an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rains at isolated places in five districts on Monday and Tuesday. Dharmsihla recorded 96.2 mm of rainfall, followed by Palampur at 55 mm and Kangra at 34.6 mm. *PTI*

Students stranded as floodwaters enter school in Odisha

400 Around 400 students, including 150 girls, were left stranded at a government-run residential school in Odisha's Kendrapara district after floodwater entered the campus on Sunday, an official said. The school is located in a low-lying area at Kulasahi village under Penthapala gram panchayat in Pattamundai block. *PTI*

Aid trucks that entered Afghanistan via Pakistan

700 More than 700 trucks carrying international humanitarian aid arrived in Afghanistan via Pakistan despite a near-total closure of the land border between the two countries in October, the United Nations said Sunday. The convoy was carrying "food and other humanitarian items," a UN spokesperson said. *AFP*

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The federal dilemma of delimitation

The Centre made an oral assurance while introducing the Bill to increase Lok Sabha seats that each State's share would increase by 50% on a pro-rata basis. However, the increase could weaken the Rajya Sabha's role as a check on the Lower House, while the Lok Sabha's limited sitting days would leave MPs with less time to raise issues

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly has passed a resolution urging the Centre to permanently freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at the existing number of 543 and maintain the present State-wise distribution of those seats. It also advocated the preservation of current ratio of 2.2:1 between Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha seats. It sought the implementation of one-third reservation of seats for women in the Lok Sabha from the 2029 election onwards, without linking it to any future census or delimitation.

Defining delimitation

Delimitation means the process of fixing the number of seats and boundaries of the territorial constituencies in each State for the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies. This 'Delimitation process' is performed by 'Delimitation Commission' that is set up under an act of Parliament. The last time when the number of seats were determined was on the basis of 1971 census population.

'Democracy' means 'rule or government by the people'. It follows that the government is elected by a majority with the broad principle of 'one citizen-one vote-one value'. Article 81(2) of the Constitution provides that the ratio between the number of seats and population of a State, shall as far as practicable be same for all the States. The number of seats in the Lok Sabha based on 1971 census was fixed at 543, when the population was 54.8 crores. This broadly translated to an average population of 10.1 lakhs per constituency. However, it has been frozen as per 1971 census in order to encourage population control measures so that States with higher population growth do not end up having higher number of seats. This was done through the 42nd Amendment Act till the year 2000 and was extended by the 84th amendment act till 2026. This number will have to be readjusted based on the first census after 2026 which would be the next census in 2027. In 2023, through the 106th Constitutional Amendment, the Parliament had provided for one-third reservation of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies. This would be through delimitation based on the census in 2027.

The issues involved

The population explosion that happened in our country during the last five decades has been uneven, with some States like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan witnessing a greater increase than States like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. The ratio between the current number of seats and the projected population of States as of 2026 does not satisfy the core democratic principle of 'one person-one vote-one value' (Table 1). On the other hand, the increase in the number of seats among various States based on the current population (to 848) is provided in Table 2. Southern States, smaller states in the North, as well as the North Eastern States, are bound to be at a disadvantage when compared to large north Indian States in such a scenario. This would be against the federal principles of our country. It also goes against the philosophy for freezing the seats as per 1971 census with the States

Representation imbalance

The redistribution of seats based on current population could put smaller and less populous States at a disadvantage



Table 1: Value of vote of each citizen based on estimated population as of 2026

State	Number of seats at present	Projected population as of 2026 (in crore)	Projected population per Lok Sabha seat (in lakh)	Value of 1 vote*
Uttar Pradesh	80	25.7	32.1	0.56
Bihar	40	13.5	33.8	0.53
Rajasthan	25	8.4	33.6	0.54
Madhya Pradesh	29	9.1	31.4	0.57
Tamil Nadu	39	7.8	20	0.9
Andhra Pradesh + Telangana	42	9.3	22.1	0.81
Kerala	20	3.6	18	1
Karnataka	28	6.9	24.6	0.73
Punjab	13	3.2	24.6	0.73
Himachal Pradesh	4	0.8	20	0.9
Uttarakhand	5	1.2	24	0.75

* Kerala calculated as 1 and States' values derived on this base

Table 2: If the number of seats is increased to 848 based on 2026 projected population

(Based on research paper of Milan Vaishnav and Jamie Hinton, for the Carnegie endowment)

State	Number of seats at present	Projected number of seats	Existing proportion	Revised proportion
Uttar Pradesh	80	143	14.7%	16.9%
Bihar	40	79	7.4%	9.3%
Rajasthan	25	50	4.6%	5.9%
Madhya Pradesh	29	52	5.3%	6.1%
Tamil Nadu	39	49	7.2%	5.8%
Andhra Pradesh + Telangana	42	54	7.7%	6.4%
Kerala	20	20	3.7%	2.4%
Karnataka	28	41	5.2%	4.8%
Punjab	13	18	2.4%	2.1%
Himachal Pradesh	4	4	0.7%	0.5%
Uttarakhand	5	7	0.9%	0.8%
Total	543	848		

that have been better at controlling the population losing out on their political significance.

Current proposal by the Centre

The Union government had introduced the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill in April 2026 to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from existing 550 to 850. The Home Minister made an oral assurance in the Parliament that the number of seats in each State/Union Territory would be increased by 50% on a pro-rata basis. However, this bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha. There are expectations that the government may introduce the bill again, in the near future with explicit provisions for 50% increase in seats for all States/Union Territories on a pro-rata basis.

The larger implications

The are two main arguments in support of the proposal for 50% pro-rata increase. First, it would not alter the current proportion of representation of various States/Union Territories in the Lok Sabha. Second, it would enable seamless reservation of one-third seats for women with the additional 272 seats being reserved for women out of the enlarged house of around 816 seats.

However, such an increase has its share of challenges. Firstly, the current strength of Rajya Sabha is 245 that results in a ratio of 2.2:1 between the total strength of Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha. An increase in Lok Sabha seats by 50% without altering seats in Rajya Sabha would skew this ratio to 3.3:1.

In the event of disagreement between the two houses on any bill, there is a mechanism for Joint Sitting under the Constitution to resolve the deadlock. Though used rarely in the past (only 3 times since Independence), this increased strength in the Lok Sabha runs the risk of rise in such joint sittings to push through Bills. In such a scenario, it would diminish the role of the Rajya Sabha as an effective check and balance on the Lok Sabha. Secondly, considering that the Lok Sabha sits for only around 60 days in a year, there would hardly be any meaningful time for each MP to raise their issues in the house. The purpose of the house would then be reduced to mere numerical representation rather than meaningful deliberation.

Finally, the increased cost to the exchequer because of additional MPs including allocation for the Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS) funds needs to be

borne in mind.

Harmonious reconciliation

The issue arises as the democratic and federal principles seem to be at loggerheads in the delimitation exercise as currently envisaged. However, they can be harmoniously reconciled by giving equal importance to both. The main work of a Member of Parliament is to legislate on the 'Union List' subjects such as defence, external affairs, railways, telecommunication, taxation etc. and hold the Central government accountable. A majority of the schemes of the Central Government are implemented only by the State governments. Hence, the number of MPs in Lok Sabha may be frozen at the present number of 543, which would ensure no disruption to the current representation of various States. This would maintain and uphold the federal principle. One-third reservation for women can be provided out of the existing 543 seats. The number of MLAs in each State may be increased in line with the current population to address the democratic representational requirement. (Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'. He currently trains at 'Officers IAS Academy'. Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

➤ The Union government introduced the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill in April 2026 to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from the existing 550 to 850.

➤ The Tamil Nadu Assembly recently passed a resolution urging the Centre to permanently freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at 543 and maintain the present State-wise distribution of seats.

➤ The ratio between the current number of seats and the projected population of States as of 2026 does not satisfy the principle of 'one person, one vote, one value'. However, increasing the number of seats based on current population would put smaller and less populous States at a disadvantage.

CACHE



Digital trail: How exactly the watermarking technology works for Claude text is not yet clear, but users have expressed concerns. REUTERS

Understanding Anthropic’s move to watermark Claude AI content

While many regulators want AI content to be more clearly labelled, Claude users worry about their written work being flagged as AI; although watermarks provide a reliable way to verify the origin of images and videos, accurately detecting AI-generated text is uncharted territory.

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far: A s part of its measures to comply with the European Union’s AI Act, the Google and Amazon-backed Anthropic announced that Claude content in the future will carry a machine-readable marking to better enable AI content labelling.

Adding a watermark to AI images and videos is not a new concept. However, the update that made waves was Anthropic announcing that it would add a watermark to Claude text as well, potentially forcing millions to reconsider their use of AI tools. This update will be globally implemented.

What is the new watermarking system by Anthropic?

The new policy was introduced after Anthropic signed the EU AI Act’s Article 50(2) Code of Practice on Transparency of AI-Generated Content.

In order to better identify content that Claude has generated and/or processed, Anthropic is set to add watermarks embedded in text content, as well as signed provenance metadata attached to supported files in formats such as .svg, .png, or .jpg.

Regarding the text-based watermark applied at the model level, users will not be able to see it and Anthropic has confirmed that it will not affect Claude’s responses.

However, one statement in particular

caught the attention of AI users: “Because the watermark is part of the text, it will travel with the text when it’s copied and pasted elsewhere, and may persist through some editing.”

In essence, this update forces millions of Claude customers to entirely reconsider their use of AI tools. Professional emails, personal messages, school assignments, workplace deliverables, and other types of written content that could once be passed off easily as human-made, may soon come with an AI watermark – even if Claude’s involvement was close to negligible.

How exactly the watermarking technology works in the case of Claude text is not yet clear, as the rollout announcement did not reveal the full technical details.

Furthermore, Anthropic is still working on letting external parties detect the Claude AI markings. More information is expected in the future.

Output from the Claude Platform (API), Claude, Claude Code, Claude Cowork, and Claude Tag are set to get the embedded watermarks. The same applies when Claude models are accessed through AWS, Google Cloud, and Microsoft Foundry.

Why are Claude users and non-users concerned?

While some praised Anthropic’s marking policy in the hopes of seeing more clearly labelled AI-generated content, critics argued that Claude adding a watermark even to lightly edited text could put

reputations at serious risk.

For example, if a human-made file is proofread, translated, summarised, or even converted by someone else using Claude, the final output could still carry a mark, according to Anthropic’s update. Naturally, this has put both AI users as well as non-users on edge.

Anthropic also warned about the possibility of false positive and false negative results: detecting a Claude mark does not confirm that the work was created by AI, while the lack of a mark does not mean the work was 100% human-made.

Some factors that can throw off results include short text lengths, content changes after Claude processing, metadata being stripped by converting the file format, and the use of a Claude offering that does not yet support AI marking.

In the days following Anthropic’s announcement, multiple dubious websites claiming to offer Claude AI watermark ‘removal’ or ‘clean up’ services have come online.

These concerns are not new. The earlier rise of a market for AI text detectors – and subsequently, AI text humanisers designed to deceive these same detectors – has resulted in multiple authors and bloggers being accused of passing off AI content as original creations.

Despite AI text detection tools being experimental, fallible, and prone to errors, they have been involved in cases that led to cancelled book deals and social

media trolling.

Claude users now fear that their own AI tool could end up damaging their credentials.

Are watermarks effective at stopping fake AI content?

Watermarks certainly help simplify the jobs of regulators, fact-checkers, and journalists by giving them a reliable way to verify the origin of an image or a video and even trace it back to a specific provider. But accurately detecting AI-generated text is uncharted territory.

What’s more, AI-generated content often travels far and can be circulated thousands of times on social media unchecked, as content moderation rules have been loosened across Mark Zuckerberg’s Meta family of apps and Elon Musk’s X.

The average internet user distractedly scrolling through media on their phone often misses even visible AI watermarks, let alone invisible markings.

Tech providers and regulators will need to work hand-in-hand to make sure that the AI watermarks lead to a tangible reduction in misinformation, deepfakes, or AI content being passed off as human-made.

For now, however, Claude users are rethinking their workflows and debating at what point human content turns into AI content. Anthropic’s watermarking initiative for AI text is an intriguing concept, but it is too soon to tell if this approach to labelling will lead to more clarity or create more confusion.



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The college’s science lab is antiquated

The Principal received a shoal of petitions to replace the equipment

S. Upendran

What is the difference between ‘old fashioned’ and ‘antiquated’? (Anil Surana, Jaipur)

One of the meanings the two words have in common is ‘not modern’, ‘outdated’. Unlike ‘old fashioned’, ‘antiquated’ carries with it a very negative meaning. When you say that a gadget is antiquated, it suggests that the gadget in question is so outdated, that in today’s world, it serves no purpose. It has been replaced by something much more efficient. You are being critical of it. For example, today the old audio compact cassette tapes and floppy discs would be considered antiquated – nobody uses them anymore. They are no longer fit for the purpose for which they were originally designed.

The Government hospital is planning to replace the antiquated X-ray machines.

We need to change some of our antiquated laws.

When you refer to something as being ‘old fashioned’, it does not always have a negative connotation. For example, when one talks about ‘old fashioned values’, it suggests they are something which you are nostalgic about; something which you truly value. Unlike ‘antiquated’, ‘old fashioned’ suggests that something is charming. Something that is antiquated, usually needs to be replaced; old fashioned dresses can still be worn today. They may look dated, but are functional.

Whenever Hema visits her grandmother, she jots down some old-fashioned recipes.

These old-fashioned houses are so cool during the summer.

What is the meaning of automania? (Banu Varma, Kochi)

The term has two very different meanings. In everyday contexts, we often shorten the word automobile to ‘auto’. When used in this manner, ‘automania’ refers to someone who is crazy or excessively enthusiastic about cars and driving fast.

As a teenager, Karthik had a severe case of automania.

The word ‘auto’ has another meaning as well; it can be used to refer to oneself. A person who has ‘automania’ is obsessed about himself; he is an egomaniac. He believes he is the most important person wherever he goes. He is very self-centred.

What is the meaning of ‘shoal of fish’? How is the word ‘shoal’ pronounced? (Kavitha Kumar, Vellore)

The ‘sh’ is like the ‘sh’ in ‘ship’, ‘sheep’ and ‘shy’, while the following ‘oa’ sounds like the ‘o’ in ‘go’ ‘so’ and ‘no’. The word rhymes with ‘pole’, ‘hole’ and ‘mole’. According to scholars, ‘shoal’ comes from the Old English ‘scol’ meaning ‘crowd of fish’. Today, a large group of fish swimming together is frequently referred to as a ‘shoal of fish’ or a ‘school of fish’.

We saw several shoals of fish when we went snorkelling.

‘Shoal’ can also be used with people. One can describe a large group of people as a ‘shoal of people’. We can use the word with things as well.

A shoal of the star’s fans made their way into the court.

Word of the day

Decadence:

the state of being degenerate in mental or moral qualities

Synonym: degeneration

Usage: The leader’s decadence became evident in his abuse of power.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/decadence

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈdeɪkədəns/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Text & Context’

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on Indonesia, as the Asian country observes its Independence Day today

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1

Indonesia is the largest of this type of political entity, with over 17,000 islands between the Indian and Pacific oceans under its control. What type of state?

QUESTION 2

Name the first president of Indonesia from 1945 to 1967 and his daughter who also held the office between 2001 and 2004.

QUESTION 3

Name the invisible biogeographical boundary – running between Bali and Lombok, and between Borneo and Sulawesi – that separates Asian and Australian wildlife zones within Indonesia.

QUESTION 4

Name the Indonesian textile art using wax, that was given a UNESCO Intangible

Cultural Heritage status in 2009, and made famous by the type of shirts that Nelson Mandela sported frequently.

QUESTION 5

What is Indonesia’s National emblem, which gets its name from a bird from Indian mythology and the 5 principles of the country’s national ideology.

QUESTION 6

Indonesia is relocating its capital away from Jakarta to a purpose-built city in Borneo. What is it called?

QUESTION 7

Indonesia is home to the world’s largest Buddhist temple, built in the 9th-century in Central Java, with nine stacked platforms and thousands of relief panels. Name this UNESCO World Heritage Site.

QUESTION 8

Name the real-life couple who gave Indonesia its first-ever Olympic gold medals in 1992 and in which sport?



Visual question: Name this creature, considered the largest extant lizard, which gets its name from an Indonesian island to which it is endemic. [APF](https://www.apf.com)

Questions and answers to the previous daily quiz:

1. Name of the organisation that Fidel and his comrades started to commemorate the failed attacks on the Moncada barracks. **Ans: 26th July Movement**
 2. Name of the speech (the English translation) that Fidel gave in the trial following the Moncada barracks attack. **Ans: History will absolve me**
 3. The boat that carried Fidel and 81 of his companions from Tuxpan in Mexico to Playa Las Coloradas. **Ans: Granma**
 4. The record for the longest speech in the UN belongs to an Indian diplomat/minister. Name him. **Ans: V.K. Krishna Menon**
 5. Name of the brigade of medical professionals, established by Fidel, that was deployed across the world during health crises. The claim to fame of the world after whom the brigade was named. **Ans: Henri Reeve Brigade, named after a New York born American who participated in the Cuban war of independence from Spain**
- Visual: The three comrades of Fidel – second from left (standing), fourth from left (sitting). **Ans: Ernesto “Che” Guevara, Raul Castro and Juan Almeida**
- Early birds: Siddhartha Viswanathan | Prem Nath Tiwari | Sumana Dutta | Nairah Hussain | Lalchand Bhutani

From Page One

Dhaka sets 'conditions' for PM Rahman's visit

The Bangladeshi spokesperson confirmed the consultation and said, "Officials of Bangladesh and India have been in touch with each other for several weeks on the possibility of a bilateral visit by Honourable Prime Minister Mr. Tarique Rahman to India. However, this process was vitiated by the open press interaction in New Delhi on August 5 by Sheikh Hasina..."

Earlier, on August 7, Mr. Jaiswal had distanced India from Ms. Hasina's press conference saying that India does not "endorse" the comments made against the "duly constituted government" of Bangladesh.

In Sunday's remarks, Mr. Karim reiterated Dhaka's "Bangladesh first" foreign policy and said the government will continue to "promote friendly bilateral relations with other countries" including with neighbours, "on the basis of sovereign equality, national dignity, non-interference in each other's internal affairs and mutual benefit". Ms. Hasina sought refuge in India on August 5, 2024, after a popular uprising toppled her government.

NTA orders re-test for 3 UGC-NET papers

"The committee found that the three papers had many factual, typographical, and translation errors, including misspell names of prominent scholars, garbled book titles, errors in the stem wording of questions, grammatical errors, gender and number agreement errors, punctuation mistakes, and non-standard coined terms for established concepts, as well as repetition of a significant number of questions previously administered," he added.

In a notice, the NTA said that the "papers carrying such defects do not meet the standards of fairness and error-free examination."

"Further details of city, centre, and admit card will be notified separately on the official website. No additional examination fee will be charged from the candidates of these three subjects for the re-conduct," the NTA said.

Jharkhand govt. invites protesters for talks

Hundreds of students have gathered at the stadium in the State capital since July 25, demanding a CBI inquiry into alleged irregularities in the government job recruitment exams.

Ravindra Paswan, the leader of the JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, said that when the students' agitation began, Mr. Gandhi, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, had assured them that if Mr. Soren did not take any positive steps regarding their demands or provide a satisfactory response by August 15, the Congress would withdraw its support to the JMM-led government. However, even after August 15, the government has not taken any concrete steps to address their demands, Mr. Paswan said. "We have already announced that if the government does not listen to our demands by August 18, we will gherao the CM's residence on August 20. We have no other option left," he said.

Kumar Rajat, the Sub-Divisional Officer (SDO) of Ranchi Sadar, and Dhananjay Kumar, Additional District Magistrate (ADM), Law and Order met the protesting students at the site in the evening with the government's proposals. Mr. Rajat told *The Hindu* that students have been invited by the government to hold talks between 2 p.m. and 3 p.m. on Monday, at the State guest house in Ranchi.

Leader of the Opposition in the Jharkhand Assembly Babul Marandi posted a video of the effigy burning by demonstrators on X. "The students have given a clear message to Chief Minister Hemant Soren and Rahul Gandhi through the effigy burning that they are not ones to bow down," Mr. Marandi said in his post.

Armed forces to provide list of retiring Agniveers

Over the past month, CAPFs such as the CRPF, the SSB, and Assam Rifles have issued notifications, specifying 50% reservation for the ex-Agniveers. As reported by *The Hindu*, the Border Security Force (BSF) was the first to issue such a notification on December 19, 2025, enhancing the quota from 10% to 50%.

The ex-Agniveers will be exempted from written examinations, physical standard tests, and physical efficiency tests, the notifications said. Recruitment to the post of Constable (General Duty) will be carried out through direct recruitment, with 50% of vacancies reserved for ex-Agniveers, the CRPF's notification, issued on July 27 said.

"In the first phase, the concerned nodal force will conduct recruitment to fill the vacancies earmarked for ex-Agniveers, or in accordance with instructions issued by the MHA from time to time.

In the second phase, recruitment for the remaining 50% of vacancies will be conducted through an open examination under the existing recruitment provisions. Any vacancies reserved for ex-Agniveers that remain unfilled in the first phase will be added to the vacancies to be filled in the second phase," the CRPF said.

'No private data sought for Census; ID details will be collected only if available'

J&K, Ladakh Census chief says data is confidential under Census Act; he asks people to write down answers beforehand as number of questions has increased; warns people to be aware of cyberfraud, encourages self-enumeration; Phase 2 of Census begins in snow-bound areas from today

INTERVIEW

Amit Sharma

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Registrar-General and Census Commissioner of India (RG&CC) on August 14 notified 40 questions for Population Enumeration, the second phase of the Census 2027, which will begin in Ladakh and snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand from Monday and continue till September 30, ahead of the rest of the country, where the exercise will be held in February 2027.

The Census 2027 questionnaire will include 13 new questions that were not part of the Census 2011 questionnaire, which had 29 questions. The new questions seek information on the spouse's name, nationality, father and mother's particulars, digital literacy, permanent address, place of COVID-19 vaccination, number of bank accounts, passport, driving licence and mobile, Aadhaar and voter ID num-

bers, if available.

Amit Sharma, Chief Principal Census Officer and Director, Census Operations, Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh, speaks to *The Hindu* about the Census 2027 exercise and its significance for the two Union Territories.

Other than caste enumeration, the Population Census 2027 will also enumerate new data fields such as place of COVID-19 vaccination, identity documents and particulars of parents. What is the rationale behind the inclusion of such questions?

The questions are decided after several rounds of discussions with all Minis-

ters. No private or confidential data is being sought by enumerators; these are all documents provided by the government. We are not seeking the bank account details, only the number of accounts an individual has.

The identity documents such as Aadhaar, voter ID, driving licence, and passport are all issued by the government, and respondents are to provide them, subject to availability.

All data is confidential under the Census Act, 1948. It is better if respondents write down their details on paper before an enumerator comes. Since there are 40 questions, it may take more time.

How will self-enumeration work

in J&K and Ladakh?

Self-enumeration in the entire Union Territory of Ladakh and in the snow-bound areas of 16 districts of J&K will begin on Monday on the web portal before door-to-door enumeration begins on September 1. We would encourage people to self-enumerate. Beware of cyber fraud; fraudsters may seek information in the name of the Census. Our enumerators have QR-code-enabled ID cards; their credentials can be checked.

The self-enumeration option will be georeferenced and available only in the snow-bound areas. So, even if a resident of a snow-bound area of a district in J&K, say Gurez, who is presently in the plains, will not be able to access the portal.

Under the extended de facto pattern, everyone present at a location will be counted. More than 6.67 lakh households in J&K and 7,009 households in Ladakh voluntarily completed self-enumeration before the House Listing Operations (HLO), the first phase, in June.

Why is Census 2027

significant for J&K and Ladakh?

It will provide the first comprehensive demographic picture of Jammu & Kashmir after the abrogation of Article 370 and the first Census of Ladakh as a Union Territory. Beyond updating population figures after over a decade, it will generate data on population distribution, migration, age structure, housing, education, employment, fertility, disability and social composition to support planning and resource allocation.

Why is geography a key focus?

Demographic realities vary sharply across urban centres, border districts, remote mountain villages and tribal areas. Census 2027 aims to capture not just population numbers, but where people live, how they live, how they move and how those patterns are changing.

What are the main enumeration challenges in J&K and Ladakh?

J&K's population is spread across cities, villages,

mountainous regions, border areas and tribal habitations. Seasonal migration further complicates enumeration.

Ladakh's population lives across a vast high-altitude region marked by dispersed settlements, difficult connectivity, seasonal accessibility and remote locations. The Census must accurately capture where people live and how the population distribution varies.

How will nomadic communities and displaced populations be counted?

Special coordination with departments dealing with forests, tribal affairs and local administration will help identify migratory routes and seasonal settlements of Gujjar-Bakarwals and other nomadic groups. The objective is to ensure that mobility does not lead to undercounting.

Communities such as Kashmiri Pandits will be recorded according to established Census concepts and reference dates, while capturing migration and household characteristics.

For the full interview: newsth.hindu.com/amitsharma

Three arrested after Bengal CJP activist's father dies in attack

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Three persons were arrested on Sunday after the father of a Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) volunteer died on Saturday of injuries suffered in an attack on Thursday in West Bengal's Bankura.

The CJP has claimed that local Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) workers attacked Janab Mafik, father of Shaikh Abdul Hafeez, the CJP volunteer.

However, West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari dismissed the allegation and said a first information report (FIR) was lodged against five persons, three of whom were arrested.

"Of the five persons against whom an FIR has been registered, three have already been arrested. The two others will also be arrested. There is no BJP connection here. They are all criminals," Mr. Adhikari told presspersons.

Officials said the incident took place at Bankura's Karisunda on Thursday after Mr. Hafeez went to 'inspect' a government

school as part of the CJP's 'School Think Karo' campaign. Mr. Hafeez had attended the CJP's protest last month at Delhi's Jantar Mantar demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister.

"At night, five BJP workers attacked my house. They were looking for me but launched a brutal attack on my father after they could not find me. He sustained grievous injuries and was rushed to the Bardhaman Medical College, where he passed away," Mr. Hafeez told presspersons.

Dipke condoles death

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke issued a statement condoling the death.

"CJP stands firmly with Abdul and his family. We demand the immediate arrest of those responsible for his father's death. And to the hatemongers who think they can silence us through violence: we are not going to back off. Attack our members, threaten us, try to intimidate us, we will only fight harder," he posted on X.

RJD targets BJP over alleged irregularities in purchase of dustbins for Bihar hospitals

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

A video report on the purchase of medical dustbins for hospitals across Bihar has triggered a row after it went viral on social media. Described in the report as a "scam worth several crores of rupees" and allegedly occurred during the tenure of the previous State Health Minister Mangal Pandey, the Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) called the ruling BJP "trash bin eaters".

RJD chief Lalu Prasad's Singapore-based daughter Rohini Acharya took a jibe in a post on social media asking, "Is it a box to keep garbage in, or a new gimmick to empty the government's treasury?"

According to the report, the Bihar Medical Services and Infrastructure Corporation Limited (BMSICL) had purchased specialised hospital dustbins during the previous NDA regime headed by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, in which an alleged scam of over ₹300 crore had happened.

Is it a box to keep garbage in or a new gimmick to empty the government's treasury?

ROHINI ACHARYA
RJD chief Lalu Prasad's daughter

Mr. Pandey, a resident of Siwan district of Bihar, has been winning Assembly elections from the same seat in the BJP ticket. Mr. Pandey could not be reached till the filing of the report. The State government has not issued an official clarification regarding the alleged dustbin scam yet.

The report alleged that 75-litre plastic dustbins, priced between ₹1,000 and ₹1,500, were purchased at ₹15,490 each, while 45-litre dustbins were procured at ₹11,000 a piece despite having an alleged market price of ₹700. According to the report, the purchases made for hospitals across Bihar point to an alleged scam exceeding ₹300 crore, a figure that it said could rise

to nearly ₹700 crore.

However, a BMSICL employee, speaking on condition of anonymity, dismissed the allegations as "rubbish", saying the procured dustbins were "high-temperature and heat-resistant specialised plastic containers designed for use with advanced hospital microwave-based medical waste treatment systems, along with medical-grade disposable liners".

Meanwhile, the Opposition RJD, in a post on social media on Saturday, said, "Bihar's corrupt government bought a ₹500 dustbin for ₹15,490 and pulled off a scam worth ₹617 crore. The corruption that BJP does is of a *sattvic* (pure and clean) nature because the corrupt and the beneficiaries have so much social capital that no one calls them 'trash bin eaters'. In an apparent reference to Mr. Pandey's picture, the post further said, "In the picture is Mangal Pandey ji, who set the Health Department ablaze and cleaned up the dustbin itself".

U.P. to train 10,000 'Gau Mitras' for cow protection

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Uttar Pradesh government on Sunday announced plans to train 10,000 'Gau Mitras' for its cow protection campaign, with the aim of sensitising the younger generation.

"The Yogi Adityanath government is preparing to involve the new generation, particularly Gen Z, in its cow protection campaign across Uttar Pradesh. Through village-level campaigns, young people will be made aware about cow protection, cow service and its social and economic significance. Around 10,000 'Gau Mitras' will be prepared for this purpose. Master trainers will first be trained, who will subsequently train others," reads an official statement.

Large-scale campaign

At present, a large-scale campaign is being undertaken in the State for the protection and upkeep of stray and destitute cattle. More than 7,500 cow shelters have been developed across the State, housing over 1.2 million cattle.

Three arrested in West Bengal over suspected Pakistan links

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The Special Task Force (STF) of the West Bengal police on Saturday arrested three persons from Sahebganj in Cooch Behar district for suspected links with the Pakistan-based intelligence agency, Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI).

The development comes three days after the STF arrested two persons, including Pakistani national Rana Rauf, from North 24 Parganas's Bongaon for

allegedly spying on Indian Railway services and Indian Army on behalf of the ISI since 2012.

The three accused were identified as Rashidul and Nasiruddin, residents of Sahebganj, and Safikul.

"Acting on a tip-off, the STF team conducted a search operation at their places in Sahebganj on Saturday in the wee hours. We have also seized some Indian SIM cards from the accused. Prima facie, they used to smuggle those SIM cards to Pakistan through

Bangladesh. They have also been running a counterfeit Indian currency racket for the last few years," said the Police Superintendent of STF (North Bengal), Y. Raghuvamshi.

Produced in court

The accused were produced before a Dinhatia court on Saturday that sent them to the 14-day police custody. The STF is now interrogating them to trace their other associates and their communication channels with the ISI.

Farmers' march to Delhi stopped at Haryana-Punjab boundary

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

A group of around 200 farmers and supporters led by Samyukta Kisan Morcha (Non-Political) leader Jagjit Singh Dallowal was stopped by the Haryana Police at the Khanauri-Da Singhla boundary in Jind on Sunday while marching on foot towards Delhi as part of a 13-day 'Kisan Bachao Padayatra' (Save Farmers Walk).

Several farmer leaders were also taken into pre-

ventive detention. The group was heading towards Delhi's Jantar Mantar to press for a range of demands, including exclusion of agriculture from the proposed India-U.S. trade agreement; a legal guarantee for Minimum Support Price (MSP); waiver of farmers' loans; and withdrawal of police cases registered against farmers during agitations.

The farmers were scheduled to reach Jantar Mantar on August 29. The farmers were marching

peacefully on foot and had not brought tractors or trolleys, Mr. Dallowal told *The Hindu*. The government had earlier said that the farmers would be allowed to proceed if they came on foot, he added.

The Haryana Police, in anticipation of the march, had sealed the stretch between the Khanauri boundary in Punjab and the Da Singhla in Haryana with concrete barriers and barbed wire. Heavy security was deployed around the Narwana canal bridge.

IN BRIEF



One of Assam's sharpest wildlife guard dogs retires

One of Assam's sharpest wildlife guard dogs retired from service on India's 80th Independence Day. Leon, a Belgian Malinois, tracked wildlife crime suspects, assisted in anti-poaching operations, and guarded some of Assam's most precious fauna. The highlight of his career was guiding Assam Forest Department and police personnel to a rhino poacher after following the suspect's scent trail for nearly 20 km across several forest camps and security checkpoints during the 2019 floods. On Saturday, the Forest Department and police retired Leon with official honours in recognition of his service since joining field duty in November 2018.

Navy sailor, wife, 2 children found dead in Mumbai home

The bodies of an Indian Navy sailor, his wife, and their two children were recovered from their official accommodation at Navy Nagar in Mumbai's Colaba on Saturday, prompting the police and naval authorities to launch separate investigations. Naval security personnel and the Mumbai Police were alerted after the family did not respond to telephone calls. A subsequent check of the quarters resulted in the recovery of the bodies. A statement issued by the Navy said the police have registered a case and initiated an inquiry. The residence has been sealed, and a forensic team has examined the premises. "We are providing all assistance to the civil police in their investigation," a Navy representative said.

2 staff injured as passenger's gun goes off at airport in U.P.

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Two workers involved in baggage screening were injured at the Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport in Varanasi on Sunday when a passenger's pistol went off accidentally.

Air India Express passenger Kamlesh Rai, a resident of Azamgarh district in Uttar Pradesh, declared a licensed firearm (7.62 mm pistol with 21 live cartridges) at the check-in counter at the airport as required under the prescribed procedure.

During the inspection of the weapon, it accidentally went off, with a bullet hitting Rohit Raj and Suman Kumari, who were involved in in-line baggage screening.

Ms. Kumari was injured in her leg and Mr. Raj in his thumb. Both were admitted to hospital.

"Today, 16.08.2026, at about 0930 hrs, a passenger travelling with his wife on flight IX-1810 to Mumbai declared weapons (to be carried) on board the flight. During the weapons check, a round went off..., injuring two AAICLAS screeners. Local police have been informed, and an investigation is under way," read a statement by Varanasi Airport Authority.

Panel flags absence of policy to shut mines in Meghalaya

High Court-constituted committee questions the State's lethargy in adopting the policy to close all rat-hole mine openings; the State had been advised years ago to seal illegally operated mines

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A panel constituted by the High Court has flagged the State's lethargy in adopting a policy to close all rat-hole mine openings and fence those that pose danger to humans and livestock.

In its 39th Interim Report submitted to the court last week, the one-man Justice (retired) B.P. Katakey Committee underlined the absence of a comprehensive action plan, the non-adoption of a mine closure policy, and serious gaps in the scrutiny of coal-based industries, specifically coke oven plants that thrive on coal.

The panel noted that the Meghalaya government heeded some of its recommendations, but has largely ignored the mine closure policy. The State had been advised years ago to seal abandoned and active but illegally operated mines that have been death traps for humans, specifically children, and livestock.

There are also instances of murderers using these pits to dump the bodies of their victims.



Rescue operations under way at an illegal rat-hole coal mine blast site to rescue trapped mine workers, in East Jaintia Hills. FILE PHOTO

The Katakey panel says the Central Mine Planning and Design Institute Limited prepared detailed project reports (DPRs) for two pilot restoration projects — one at Sutnga in East Jaintia Hills (₹63 lakh) and the other at Arenggitim in South Garo Hills district (₹92.78 lakh).

Proposals pending

Both proposals have been pending before the National Green Tribunal-Constituted Oversight Committee, a hybrid Centre-State body comprising 12

members.

The Katakey panel observed that the DPRs focus on land restoration, but lack adequate protective measures, including fencing, until works are completed. It insisted that immediate steps are essential to prevent further loss of human and animal lives, noting that thousands of open coal mines exist across Meghalaya.

According to the Jaintia Coal Mines Owners and Dealers' Association, there are about 60,000 mines spread across 360 villages

in the East Jaintia Hills district alone. Most of these are abandoned but left uncovered.

The Katakey panel says most districts have not sent their concrete proposals on mine closure to the Mining and Geology Department. It noted that officials from South West Khasi Hills, West Khasi Hills, West Jaintia Hills, and East Jaintia Hills districts assured submission of proposals within 10 days, while South Garo Hills sought 15 days.

Illegal mining

The National Green Tribunal banned Meghalaya's hazardous rat-hole coal mining in April 2014.

The death of more than 45 miners in the narrow tunnels 150-300 metres underground over the years has indicated that mining has continued illegally in the State.

Such rat-hole mines, so called because their tunnels, branching out horizontally from a deep pit, are large enough for an adult to crawl through, are in operation along the Assam-Arunachal Pradesh and Assam-Nagaland borders, too.

FDA issues show-cause notice to actors over ad

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has issued a show-cause notice to actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn, and Tiger Shroff over their involvement in an advertisement and promotional material for "Vimal Elaichi", claiming it *prima facie* amounted to "indirect or surrogate" promotion of prohibited pan masala and tobacco-related products.

The sale of pan masala, which can include orally ingested tobacco, is prohibited in the State. The advertisement links the actors to the Vimal brand, indirectly promoting a banned product, the notice says.

'Cease participation'

The three actors came together for the ad campaign for "Vimal Elaichi" in 2024. They have now been directed to cease participation in any related advertising activities.

The FDA, under Commissioner Tukaram Mule, has directed the removal of all content associated with the advertisement, and a detailed explanation from the actors, within 19 days.

He has been in the news for enforcement actions since his appointment.

Sumit Sarkar brought ordinary people, their experiences into history books

TRIBUTE

Janaki Nair

I did not have the good fortune of being taught by Sumit Sarkar. But like every (conscientious) modern Indian historian, I have indeed been 'taught' by him. His classic, *Modern India*, modestly described as a "textbook", is perhaps the most well-thumbed of my many books. Here, along with colonial masters and nationalist leaders, peasants, workers, and ordinary people sprang from its pages.

This was no simple inclusion: it was a conceptual break, altering our understanding of Indian history in profound ways, acknowledging the lives and actions of millions, even their failures, as the true basis on which to understand our past. But political leaders, their actions, and the periodisations familiar to students of history

could not be dispensed with altogether. Therefore, the book, despite its emphasis on the novel breakthroughs of a 'history from below', was sandwiched 'between the foundation of the Indian National Congress in 1885 and the achievement of independence in 1947', since those 60 years 'witnessed perhaps the greatest transition in our country's long history'. In one memorable sentence, he signalled the many unfulfilled promises of Indian nationalism: thus, the Mahatma succeeded in 'drawing in the masses, while at the same time keeping mass activity strictly pegged down to certain forms predetermined by the leader'.

Let me not dwell on the gaping hole that Sarkar's demise had left among historians, and focus instead on the riches he has left us. His book, *Swadeshi Movement in Bengal*, on Bengal's (first) partition of 1905, and the nationalist

movement that it spawned, was full of methodological innovations, using plays, novels, newspapers, pamphlets, in addition to the more familiar colonial archive. These materials led him to ask questions that often led to ambiguous or unsatisfactory answers. Educated unemployment and rising prices surely fuelled the anger against the Bengal partition. But the pride-inducing victory of a little 'eastern' nation, Japan, over a powerful 'western' neighbour, Russia, — the Russo-Japanese war of 1904-05 — also played its part, despite a relative ignorance in India of emerging crises of imperialism elsewhere.

Sarkar also asked himself: how could a Swadeshi editorial in the *Bande Mataram* praise, in the same breath, both the labour movement and the caste system, the latter for having had 'the true socialist aim of keeping awake in every



Legacy unmatched: Historian Sumit Sarkar passed away on August 13. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

class of society a sense of duty to it?" Or, as he would ask later, what drew the upper caste men to revolutionary terrorism in Bengal, and why has that memory endured longer than those of tribal or lower caste participants?

He was among the earliest of historians to unpack how 'Hindu' nationalism gradually became 'common sense', with consequences up to this day.

Sarkar's task was to break out of the economic determinism and narrow

positivism that was the hallmark of Marxist scholarship at the time. But the work remains unsurpassed, since it upholds the protocols of historical research, the verifiability of evidence, and as he said, 'the constant knowledge that my conclusions remain open to revision and change'. Would a revised Modern India, that more correctly reflects the scholarship of the last four decades — as many regions, social groups, practices, and events have found

their historians — be at all possible in our times? How were material conditions and cultural forms to be integrated within a structured totality?

His Marxism did not come in the way of engaging with what Ranajit Guha has called the oldest (and richest) archive in India: religion. He read religion, but not as a believer; not to denigrate but to connect the celestial world to its earthly presence in meaningful ways.

In fact, Marxism enabled his interest in the 19th-century mystic (and rustic) Hindu thinker Ramakrishna. Paramahansa, the clerical ambience within which he operated, which gave his philosophy its force and material influence, especially among the emerging, well-read, urban middle class. That contradiction needed to be explained. Sarkar linked the belated entry of clock-time into India, and the

disciplinary mechanisms it generated, to the slavery of clerical labour, which paved the way for the reception of Ramakrishna.

On RSS and Left

Sarkar showed us the true meaning of engaged scholarship: when India was stunned in 1992 by the shock troops of the BJP and RSS that brought down the Babri Masjid, Sarkar and his colleagues produced a short but vital book called *Khaki Shorts and Saffron Flags*. It was the first serious historical reconstruction (based also on sensitive fieldwork) of what the RSS had become, the most formidable force on the Indian political firmament. Certainly the young people who have today given us a ray of hope should place this book at the top of their reading lists.

Sarkar, in both his writing and his political positions, was unafraid to confront the official Left and its surrender to global cap-

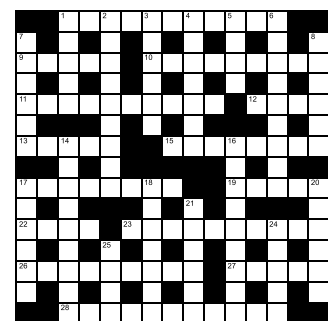
ital, as at Nandigram and Singur. He would have been the first to admit that proletarians have not been the grave diggers of capitalism, though he welcomed historians who showed renewed interest in labour and working class history.

I was personally honoured when this remarkable historian included me in his review of five such books. But more striking was his intellectual openness: his choices 'provincialised' Bengal, by acknowledging the worlds and questions that lay well beyond it — Kanpur, Jamshedpur, KGF, Bombay, the railway works.

At a time when 'everyone' is a historian, and we are being trained in thinking of history only as 'pride' in the past, we will miss complex thinkers like Sarkar even more, for his passing no doubt signals the end of an era.

(Janaki Nair is the professor (ret'd), Centre for Historical Studies, JNU)

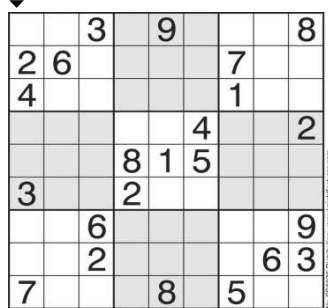
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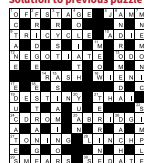
- Across
- Criminal Job's gathering (11)
 - Without males and females... (5)
 - Crooked thing — a piece of golfing equipment — in place for entertainment (9)
 - Creature and monk falling into woodworking equipment (10)
 - Weapons from Mars destroyed (4)

- Down
- Biggles' plane, perhaps, arrived at port (5)
 - Perhaps, Norse monk is not a cigar or cigarette user (3-6)
 - Having title, wrongly won gin cocktail (6)
 - Increase soldiers in month with initial threat (7)
 - A small quantity from Anzio tavern (4)
 - African flower produced by Verrier travelling around '49 (4,5)
 - Admits, "Won wrongly by tallest cat when going back" (4,2)
 - Drug addict, perhaps, from a vehicle at Emergency Room (6)
 - Dreamt SAM exploded in city (9)
 - Baked food with church male is cut bit by bit (9)
 - About female animal getting small plants once again (6)
 - Sign and kill (7)
 - Returns damaged lid? Yes! (6)
 - Arabian, perhaps, one following enemy running away (6)
 - A F-fight to get something to use with a bow (5)
 - Tea, I hear, followed tea in discussion (4)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Two forms of worship

In the Bhagavad Gita, Canto 12 is dedicated to Bhakti Yoga, the yoga of devotion, said Sri Ramanujam in a discourse. There are two primary forms of worship and meditation in Hindu philosophy — *Saguna Upasana* (manifestation form) and *Nirguna Upasana* (formless devotion). *Saguna* worship refers to devotion with attributes or with qualities, whereas *Nirguna Upasana* means devotion without attributes or formless devotion. In the Bhagavad Gita, Arjuna asks Lord Krishna which of the two paths is superior. Lord Krishna replies to Arjuna that while both paths ultimately lead to the same Supreme realisation, *Saguna Upasana*, devotion in personal form, is far easier and more practical for embodied human beings. This forms the foundational essence of Bhakti Yoga. He also explains that *Nirguna Upasana* represents a profound philosophical realisation and is exceptionally difficult for common people because the human mind and intellect naturally rely on names and forms, and need a physical sensory focus.

Saguna dhyana enhances the essence of *nirguna*. Take gold as an example: a solid bar of gold (*nirguna*) versus an intricately crafted wearable golden ornament (*saguna*). Similarly, water in a still, silent lake (*nirguna*), versus a beautifully flowing waterfall that brings joy through its movement and sound (*saguna*). Ultimately, both *saguna* and *nirguna Upasana* are two sides of the same coin, which are inseparable. *Saguna* has the added advantage of letting devotees connect emotionally, whether they view the divine as a master, a friend, a child, a beloved, or their own soul, allowing them to pray, seek compassion, and be guided.

MONEYWISE

Your portfolio without you

Vaishali R. Venkat

Imagine you are stranded in a desert with no broker's app, no Internet. Buying/selling shares or mutual funds is out of the question. You can't even check your investments.

"So what?" you may ask. "It is only a matter of a few hours." But what if you stay there for a fortnight? You somehow learn to survive, perhaps by imitating a camel. Fortunately, the camel has no portfolio to worry about; its life is free from market crashes, share-price swings and needs no Internet or broker's app.

Managing portfolio

You, however, have spent years carefully building a retirement portfolio. Now comes the acid test: what happens when you are not there to manage it? A crisis such as Chennai's December 2015 deluge, the massive Spain-Portugal power outage of April 2025, or even a prolonged technological disruption can suddenly cut you off from financial life, leaving your own money beyond your reach.

There was also an unverified account doing the rounds on social media of an investor, unable to access their portfolio during the blackout, reportedly 'travelled' nearly 2,000 km from Madrid to Italy to execute trade.

Whether the story is true or not, that's beyond our purview now. But, imagine crossing a border and travelling that far, just to reach your own investments and execute a single trade. Which brings us to the real question: if you cannot reach your portfolio for a couple of weeks, can the portfolio still do its job?

More vulnerable

A portfolio that requires you to watch it every day is vulnerable to more than just market volatility. A vacation abroad, hospitalisation, prolonged power cut owing to floods or natural disasters, lost phone, Internet outage, a few days of inattention or simply a few days away from the screen can have financial consequences, especially a loss. The Madrid investor's story, whether true or not, is an extreme illustration: if being unable to press a button can force you to change your travel plans, perhaps the investment is demanding too much from its owner.

Swing trading

For instance, this is where swing trading often gets mistaken for investing. An investor may buy shares expecting to hold them for years, sometimes decades, to build wealth for life after retirement; a swing trader may buy them expecting to sell after a quicker price move over days or weeks. Neither is inherently wrong. But the second strategy makes access and timing part of the game. If you are stranded without a phone when the price reaches the level at which you intended to sell, your absence suddenly matters. That is not necessarily a bad strategy; it is simply a strategy that cannot be treated as a set-and-forget investment. It is not an investment at all in the first place.

Try this with your portfolio: mentally switch off your phone, Internet and broker account for a fortnight. Then look at each of your investments and ask this question: "What happens if I do nothing for a month?" If the answer is "nothing", that may be a good sign. If the answer is "I must monitor, renew, switch, sell or make a decision", you have discovered something important about the investment, and about your dependence on it.

The distinction is simple: some investments can patiently wait for you; others have a clock ticking in your absence. If an investment depends on you spotting a price, pressing a button or taking a decision at precisely the right time, your absence becomes a risk in itself. A long-term portfolio should ideally have fewer such moving parts. You may be away from your portfolio; your portfolio should not be away from its purpose. Think about it.

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneynwise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



One more: Another unseen benefit is 'lifelong renewability' of hospitalisation policies. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Think before you don't renew your policy!

We tend to value visible rewards while renewing an insurance policy but rights and benefits accumulated over time, though invisible until you need them, can be far more valuable

BETWEEN THE LINES

K. Nitya Kalyani

She has insured for 11 years with not a single hospitalisation claim but no premium discount in appreciation of a profitable customer was forthcoming. So, my friend did not renew her hospitalisation policy.

Mistake. One because she did not have a fallback policy. But, more so because, in this policy, she had accumulated something. In fact, a goldmine of invisible benefits.

The policy had accrued the maximum bonus sum insured possible due to all those claim-free years. That is, instead of a cash discount, she had been given extra insurance value for the same premium.

She had also availed periodic free or subsidised master health check-ups during the years. And her time-bound exclusions were exclusions no more since the waiting periods were long over.

Expanded coverage

In other words, the scope of her coverage had expanded over time as she persisted with the policy.

We tend to value visible rewards. But rights and benefits accumulated over time, though invisible until you need them, can be far more valuable. Not for nothing is insurance called an intangible product. It is not just a money equation

of premium and claims. Not for nothing is insurance called an intangible product. It is not just a money equation of premium and claims. It's something more

of premium and claims.

Lifelong renewability Another unseen benefit is 'lifelong renewability' of hospitalisation policies.

Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), the insurance sector regulator, has made this mandatory for standard hospitalisation policies without fresh medical tests.

Accordingly, your insurance company cannot refuse renewal or hike your individual premium due to your health setbacks or claims provided you have paid your premiums on time and kept the policy active.

Exceptions are cases such as proven fraud, intentional misrepresentation, false claims, moral hazard and so on.

All these benefits and the real downside of difficulties in getting new policies as age advances makes a strong case for not throwing the baby out with the bathwater.

I only wish this friend had called before her renewal or even during the grace period. She could have kept her coverage and

The various benefits and the real downside of difficulties in getting new policies as age advances makes a strong case for not throwing the baby out with the bathwater

her well-earned benefits intact. She did contact the insurer a couple of months later to renew but it was a no go. And that is as per hospitalisation policy norms.

Losing all

Misreading, or not reading, her policy was a mistake. A bigger misstep was letting it lapse and losing it all. Both she and her agent lost something of value.

She lost her coverage; the agent lost a sale and a customer. He ought to have told her what she stood to lose. The lesson? You may have doubts and questions about the value of your insurance policy, but don't throw it away without an expert once-over.

Now, all I could tell her was to buy a policy afresh and start from square one. Harder when you are 11 years older.

Since you will be assessed anew, health status could have deteriorated and higher risk levels perceived making underwriting more difficult.

They may offer you restricted cover and higher premium. Medical tests will almost certainly be required

and certain risks can even be declined citing age and company guidelines.

You have to go through the waiting periods for pre-existing diseases all over again and there could be more of them.

Ditto for waiting periods for specified procedures and day-care surgeries. You will have to go through claim-free years again for the bonus in the form of extra sum insured to start accruing.

The Tirukkural says it best: Think before you act; there is little point in deliberating afterwards.

And this is not just about hospitalisation insurance. There are plenty of insurance decisions, acts of omission and commission, that people come to regret. I will share some of those stories in the next instalment of Between the Policy Lines.

What you are letting go

- 1) Accumulated bonuses
- 2) Waiting periods for excluded coverage
- 3) Right to renew
- 4) Loyalty and continuity benefits such as free medical check-ups and access to health and fitness apps/trackers
- 5) Anchor policy to increase sum insured
- 6) Base policy to build coverage with a top-up or super top up
- 7) Track record with the insurer and relationships built

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

Convertible, portable?

THINKINVESTOR

If you are likely to continually experience work-related relocation, then you must consider investing primarily in financial assets; buying land must be to park surplus cash, not to achieve life goal

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

The asset allocation process helps you determine how much of your savings must be allocated to each asset class. If you were to invest only in financial assets, then the process typically involves deciding how much to invest in equity and bonds. But what if you want to invest in physical assets such as real estate and commodity (read gold)? In this article, we discuss the temptation to invest in physical assets and the factors you must be mindful of before allocating your annual savings to such assets.

Investment portability

Physical assets are touch-and-feel investments, unlike financial assets that are abstract. This is a tempting benefit, as it is easy to relate to a touch-and-feel asset. Also, if these investments do not increase significantly in value, you can always convert them into consumption assets.

Take land. If you are unable to sell land at a higher price, you can build a house for self-occupation. Likewise, you can convert your physical gold bar into jewellery if the investment does not fetch good returns.

Flip side

There is the flip side to investing in physical assets. What if your work requires you to move from one city to another or from State to another? Your real estate is not portable; financial assets are. Also, it takes some effort to convert physical gold into cash. In addition, you need a safe place to store your gold and bank lockers are not easily available. Note that portability of your gold investments (taking gold with you when you relocate) depends on your ability to rent bank lockers or alternative safe storage facilities.

Conclusion

If you are likely to continually experience work-related relocation, then you must consider investing primarily in financial assets. This is not to say that you should not invest in land. But your investment in land must be to park surplus cash and not to achieve a life goal. This is because real estate investment is not liquid. That means you may be unable to convert your investment into cash at a fair price when you need the money to achieve a life goal. Note that Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are not a pure bet on real estate. That is, REITs are exposed to market risk, as they are listed on a stock exchange. So, their prices can decline when the market tanks. That said, REITs could be an optimal alternative to lumpy investments in real estate to earn rental income.

(The author offers training programs for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Axix Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-2,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,687	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,113-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

* Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.50	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50% (Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.13-11.65	10,169 - 11,029	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab & Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,847	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 4,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

* 0.25% rate concession for home loan borrowers/other clients with 6-month banking relationship
** 50% waiver on processing fee till Sept. 30
*** Up to 50% processing fee concession for PSB Aapna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on August 12

Source: Paisabazaar.com

BUCHAREST

Spanish fighter jet downs drone in Romania after airspace breach



A Spanish fighter jet on Sunday shot down a drone that had breached Romanian airspace near the border with Ukraine and Moldova, national authorities and NATO said. The interception of the drone — which entered from Moldova — was carried out by an F-18. Debris fell in an unpopulated area of the Galati region. AFP

JERUSALEM

Israel vows to go after Hezbollah as it names another killed in strikes



Israel's Defence Minister Israel Katz vowed on Sunday it would hit Hezbollah again if threatened, as it identified what it described as a commander killed in strikes a day earlier that also left several children dead. Israeli strikes on Saturday killed 11 people in south Lebanon, as per officials, in one of the deadliest attacks. AFP

CAIRO

U.S. envoy Kushner meets Hamas leader in push for a Gaza road map



U.S. negotiator and President Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner held a rare meeting with Hamas chief Khalil al-Hayya on Sunday in a new diplomatic effort to make progress in the stalled Gaza ceasefire. Mr. Kushner, along with Tony Blair and Nikolay Madenov, will meet with Israel's Prime Minister on Monday. AP

MAUMERE

Thousands evacuate after quake kills at least 53 people in Indonesia



Around 5,000 people have been evacuated after a magnitude-7.7 earthquake, the deadliest since 2022, rocked eastern Indonesia on Saturday, killing at least 53, blocking roads and causing landslides, authorities said on Sunday. They added that more than 130 people had been injured, many with broken bones. REUTERS

6 killed as Ukraine launches one of its largest aerial attacks on Russia

Russia's Defence Ministry claims it destroyed 822 Ukrainian drones, while Moscow's Mayor says about 600 were headed toward capital region; Russian missile strike hits Ukraine's largest steel producer, forcing partial suspension of operations

Associated Press
KYIV

Ukraine launched hundreds of drones across Russia on Sunday, killing at least six persons in one of Kyiv's largest aerial attacks of the war.

Kyiv has stepped up its attacks on Russia this year, with long-range missiles and swarms of drones targeting military industries and energy facilities. It has also increasingly pummeled giant Wildberries depots, burning billions of dollars' worth of merchandise belonging to the Russian online retail giant. Those attacks have



A burnt-out hypermarket following an overnight Ukrainian drone strike, in Donetsk, a Russian-held city of Ukraine on Sunday. REUTERS

brought the war home to the Russian public nearly four-and-a-half years into Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Meanwhile, Ukraine al-

so came under Russian attack, with drone strikes destroying homes and torching Kyiv's landmark book market.

Russia's Ministry of De-

fence said it had destroyed 822 Ukrainian drones overnight. Some 600 drones were detected headed toward the Russian capital, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said, with a third of those destroyed over the Moscow region itself.

An 83-year-old man was killed after a Ukrainian drone hit a private home in the Moscow region, local Governor Andrey Vorobyov said. He also confirmed that a Ukrainian attack had sparked a blaze at a Wildberries warehouse in the town of Podolsk.

A drone attack targeted three towns in Russia's southwestern Rostov region, killing five persons,

local Governor Yuri Slyusar said. The attack, with more than 150 drones, damaged several homes and a railway station and sparked a forest fire.

A Russian missile attack on Ukraine's Kryvyi Rih killed two persons and wounded 14 others, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on social media Sunday. He also said that one more person had been killed in the city of Sumy.

ArcelorMittal Kryvyi Rih, Ukraine's largest steel producer, confirmed that one of its sites had been hit in a missile attack and that operations had been partially suspended.

Sri Lanka moves to raise retirement age of judges

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

The Sri Lankan government will table a contentious Bill in Parliament this week seeking to raise the mandatory retirement age of judges of the country's Supreme Court and Court of Appeal, a move critics say could undermine the independence of the judiciary.

According to a media statement issued by Minister of Justice Harshana Nanayakkara, the government will table the proposed constitutional amendment Bill — the 22nd Amendment — on Tuesday. It seeks to amend Article 107(5) of the Constitution to raise the retirement age of Supreme Court judges from 65 to 67 years, and that of Court of Appeal judges from 63 to 65 years.

The Anura Kumara Dissanayake administration has sought to justify the move by saying it would help address the massive backlog of cases, expedite court proceedings, and ensure continuity by retaining experienced and senior judges.

The amendment would help address a backlog of approximately 1.1 million



Anura Kumara Dissanayake

pending cases, Mr. Nanayakkara, an Attorney-at-law, told presspersons.

However, the political Opposition, members of the legal fraternity and sections of civil society are fiercely opposing the move, arguing that it would impact the independence of the judiciary.

Fierce opposition

In a social media post, Leader of the Opposition Sajith Premadasa questioned why the extension [of the retirement age] must apply to sitting judges.

Amid the ongoing debate largely confined to Sri Lanka's legal fraternity and sections of civil society, a 20-member delegation of the Bar Association of Sri Lanka (BASL), a professional body of lawyers, met President Dissanayake on

August 12.

"The BASL emphasised that the proposed amendment would have a serious impact on the independence of the judiciary and that, in the circumstances, the proposed amendment should not be proceeded with. The BASL further pointed out that there are several other urgent matters requiring the attention of the government which must be given priority," the association said in a statement following the meeting.

The President's office said Mr. Dissanayake "stressed that the decision to extend the retirement age of judges was not taken with any individual or group in mind, but in the broader public interest".

Responding to the developments, Margaret Satterthwaite, UN Special Rapporteur on the independence of judges and lawyers, recently wrote to the government and noted that the amendment, in the form reportedly proposed and in its implications, "may not be in line with international human rights standards related to the independence of the judiciary and the right to a fair trial".

Mining hope



Endless toil: Adults and children search for gold at a mining site in Iga-Barriere in eastern Congo's Ituri province on Friday. Accusations of child labour, unsafe conditions, and corruption have long plagued the country's mining industry. AP

South Korea 'fires warning shots at line of demarcation'

Reuters
SEOUL

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) said on Sunday that warning shots had been fired when North Korean soldiers violated the military demarcation line between the countries, prompting them to return.

The Yonhap news agency reported earlier on Sunday that warning shots had been fired last week, citing an unnamed source.

"Recently, on the Eastern Front, North Korean forces crossed the military demarcation line, prompting our military to fire warning shots according to operational procedures," a JCS statement said.

Iran offers \$30,000 bounty for killing or capturing U.S. soldiers

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's military announced on Sunday that it was offering a bounty equivalent to \$30,000 for killing or capturing U.S. soldiers, with the reward doubled if carried out by a woman.

Army chief Amir Hatami said the plan had been drawn up following "the large number of requests" to participate in the financial support, according to the IRNA state news agency.

There has been no known deployment of United States ground forces in Iran during the West Asia war, with the exception of

a rescue mission in April for a downed American pilot.

Mr. Hatami did not provide any details on where or when the killing or capturing of U.S. soldiers was expected to take place.

"Anyone who kills or captures and hands over an invading American military personnel will receive a reward equivalent to \$30,000 or 5 billion toman from the Islamic Republic of Iran's Army," Mr. Hatami said, using an informal unit equivalent to 10,000 Iranian rials.

"Courageous Iranian women who carry out such an action will receive double the reward," he added.

Ben-Gvir advocates killing '30 to 40' people in Gaza nightly

Associated Press
JERUSALEM

An Israeli lawmaker in Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's coalition publicly advocated for killing "30 to 40" people in Gaza each night, comments that surfaced on Sunday and were quickly shared by Palestinian media.

Minister of National Security Itamar Ben-Gvir made the statement while speaking to a former Gaza-held hostage, Rom Braslavski, on Mr. Braslavski's podcast. The two were discussing Israel's recovery from the Hamas attack of October 7, 2023, when Mr. Ben-Gvir criticised Israel's recent drawdown of strikes in Gaza.



Itamar Ben-Gvir

"It's no secret, I disagree with the Prime Minister," he said. "I think targeted assassinations should be carried out in Gaza, taking down 30 to 40 every night. Not just those who pose an immediate threat — there are people there who are not worthy of life. They shouldn't live. They're not even people."

In the past, similar statements by Mr. Ben-Gvir and other Israeli officials were widely condemned. Many have been presented to the UN's world court as evidence of genocidal intent. Israel denies it has committed genocide in Gaza.

Israel's domestic media has made scarce mention of the statement, highlighting how once-fringe ideologies like Mr. Ben-Gvir's are surging in the lead-up to Israeli elections on October 27. Mr. Ben-Gvir does not have power over the country's military and cannot order strikes on Gaza. But, after operating for decades within Israel's far-right fringe, he is now one of the most influential people in the country.

GLORY IN GLASGOW



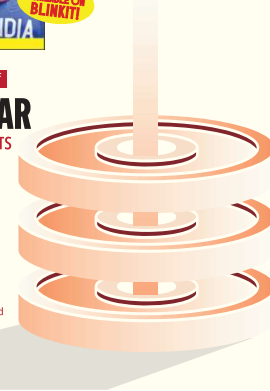
India's Commonwealth Games campaign delivered 39 medals, with weightlifting once again among the biggest contributors.

Also inside:
Plus: The life stories behind India's seven boxing golds, and how an impressive 10-metal athletics haul signals a bright future.

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"GLASGOW"



Sport

MAKING IT COUNT

Whenever he gets a chance, he scores runs: Jurel praises Padikkal



Devdutt Padikkal's maiden Test century drew praise from his India teammate Dhruv Jurel. "He was earlier here with the India-A team just like me and we played at Galle. Whenever he gets a chance, he scores runs. As a fellow cricketer, it feels good that he is doing great for India," Jurel, who had led the India-A team, said on Sunday.

IMPRESSIVE DEBUT

Nuwantha is certainly one for the future, reckons Prabath



Debutant Sri Lankan off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha found backing from senior spinner Prabath Jayasuriya. "The beauty of Test cricket is to fight it out and hang in there. The way Nuwantha has bowled on debut is superb. He was not afraid to toss it up and create opportunities. He is certainly one for the future," Prabath said.

GRACEFUL IN DEFEAT

Bangladesh outplayed us in all facets: Australia skipper Cummins



Australia captain Pat Cummins admitted that Bangladesh was too good for the home side in the first Test in Darwin. "Bangladesh was a much better side than us this [last] week. I thought that it outplayed us in all facets. Bangladesh was really patient; it did not let us back into the game and it held on to the catches."

BLUNT TALK

It's inevitable Australia has to make changes: Ponting after shock loss



I think it's inevitable that they [Australia] have to make changes. I am the last one to want to make changes. So it has to get to a bad point before I start saying you ought to leave somebody out — Former Australia captain Ricky Ponting after the team's loss to Bangladesh in the opening Test in Darwin.

Padikkal, Jurel consolidate Team India's position

The former makes 167 while the latter holds the lower-order together with a fine fifty as Gill's men reach 460 for nine at stumps on a rain-hit day; spinners Prabath, Nuwantha share seven wickets

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Sunday was largely about waiting for the sun. Fringed by the Indian Ocean and lashed by monsoon winds, Galle woke up to the pitter-patter of rains and birdsong. Umbrellas were out, puddles were the norm and the moist climate had a distinct bearing on the first Test as play resumed well after the lunch break.

Undeterred by the damp skies, India pursued its ambition of posting a healthy first-innings total against Sri Lanka. The goal was achieved with Devdutt Padikkal and Dhruv Jurel lending a hand at varying points. And at close of the second day here at the Galle International Stadium, Shubman Gill's men scored 460 for nine in 116 overs.

Conscious of inclement weather making further intrusions into the remainder of the Test, and resuming at the overnight 288 for two, India sought urgent runs. Centurion Padikkal continued unhindered while Rishabh Pant lashed left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya for four. The host skipper Dhananjaya de Silva quickly sought the new ball and employed pace and spin in tandem. Pant miscued a hoick off Keshara Nuwantha, and K.L. Rahul returned to the crease.

Rahul, however, had a brief tenure and succumbed to Nuwantha for 82 (175b, 10x4, 1x6) as the debutant off-spinner found turn and appreciable bounce. At the other end



In the thick of it: Jurel hit four fours and a six in his 68-ball 51. PTI

Padikkal went past 150 with a whipped four off seamer Asitha Fernando.

With Jurel for company, Padikkal (167, 230b, 15x4, 1x6) was busy shifting gears when he got stumped off Prabath.

Ravindra Jadeja strode in and he too preferred flamboyance over dogged resistance. Even as he departed, Jurel extended India's quest for a 400-plus

score. He hoisted Nuwantha for six.

There is a calm air that Jurel always exudes, and he became the lower-order spine. Along with Manav Suthar, he hustled the runs.

It needed a sharp catch from Dhananjaya stationed at first slip for Jurel (51, 68b, 4x4, 1x6) to depart after he prodded at Prabath. Mohammed Siraj jauntily

walked in, hit a six, played and missed, and even as the tail wobbled, India would like to believe that this has enough to dominate this opening fixture.

Earlier, persistent rains washed away the first session.

The persevering ground-staff did their best but with dark clouds often rolling in, they had a daunting task of keeping



Bouncing back: The wily Prabath sent back Padikkal, Jurel and Suthar on day two. AFP

SCOREBOARD

INDIA — 1ST INNINGS
Yashasvi Jaiswal run out 32 (37b, 5x4), K.L. Rahul c Nishan b Nuwantha 82 (175b, 10x4, 1x6), Devdutt Padikkal st. Dickwella b Prabath 167 (230b, 15x4, 1x6), Shubman Gill c Udara b Prabath 16 (28b, 2x4), Rishabh Pant c Dimutha b Nuwantha 39 (62b, 4x4, 1x6), Dhruv Jurel c Dhananjaya b Prabath 51 (68b, 4x4, 1x6), Ravindra Jadeja lbw b Nuwantha 13 (25b, 4x4), Manav Suthar c Udara b Prabath 24 (43b, 2x4), Mohammed Siraj c Dhananjaya b Asitha 11 (25b, 1x6), Kuldeep Yadav (batting) 12

(13b, 2x4), Prasidh Krishna (batting) 1 (4b); Extras (b-4, lb-3, nb-4, w-1): 12; Total (for nine wkts. in 116 overs): 460.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-47 (Jaiswal, 10.6 overs), 2-236 (Gill, 61.5), 3-307 (Pant, 80.4), 4-319 (Rahul, 84.1), 5-387 (Padikkal, 91.3), 6-577 (Jadeja, 98.1), 7-432 (Jurel, 109.1), 8-447 (Siraj, 112.6), 9-447 (Suthar, 113.1).

SRI LANKA BOWLING

Asitha 17-1-61-1, Kumara 13-1-76-0, Nuwantha 39-1-175-3, Prabath 39-6-109-4, Dhananjaya 4-0-15-0, Dimutha 4-0-17-0.

the turf dry. Like the "Myth of Sisyphus", their effort seemed akin to rolling a boulder uphill.

Coach Gautam Gambhir and batting coach Sitanshu Kotak stepped out and inspected the outfield. Bowling coach Morne Morkel bonded with fellow South African and current Sri Lankan coach Gary Kirsten. And finally when play was about to resume,

another wet spell forced the players to hurry back to the pavilion.

Thankfully, the sun enforced its will and the game commenced at 2.35 p.m., and it was India's turn to press forward in a contest that is bound to be held hostage by brooding skies. There is a forecast for more rains in the coming days and every session will be crucial.

I do what the team needs me to: Jurel

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Progress in a Test is not just about the big knock or the five-for spell, equally it is about efficient performances that slip into the shadows. Dhruv Jurel's 51 was a vital contribution during India's first innings in the opening Test against Sri Lanka, and the wicket-keeper-batter said: "Whenever I go in, I just think about what the team needs."

Speaking to the media at the Galle International Stadium on Sunday, Jurel added: "There is no personal milestone that I look for before batting. I listen to the captain and coach. I go there and do what the team needs, I try to control the situation for the team. It is about being switched on. I had played in the A-series earlier here and I had an idea about the pitch and the weather."

No pressure

Asked if he felt any pressure over his spot in the playing XI, ahead of this game, Jurel countered: "Not at all. I am very grateful that I have the opportunity to represent India. That's the only privilege that I play for."

And as for the urgency on display from the Indian batters, Jurel said: "The plan was to make as many runs as possible by playing sensible cricket. Be it Rishabh Pant or me or the tail, we wanted runs on the board."

Having wrested the in-



Jurel. GETTY IMAGES

ital honours during the first innings, Jurel felt that now it is the turn of the Indian bowlers to drive home the advantage.

"Satisfaction is about winning the match. Our bowlers have to be consistent, bowl long spells. There is no rocket science. We need to put the ball in right areas and get those 20 wickets. Our score of 450-odd is very good on this pitch."

Jurel also pointed out the value of the extended time that India had in Sri Lanka ahead of the Tests. "For India, it is all about volume. We came here 10 days before and trained at Colombo. We had many sessions. Batting on these surfaces helps us improve, and we become aware about the environment and the situation."

The remainder of this rain-affected Test would be interesting and Jurel said: "The three days will be crucial. We have to work hard on all these days. We cannot be thinking about the time we lost to the rains".

Bangladesh earns maiden Test victory in Australia

Agence France-Presse
DARWIN

A dominant Bangladesh stunned Australia to win the first game by nine wickets here on Sunday for a historic maiden Test victory on Australian soil.

After bowling Australia out for 284 in its second innings and needing just 57 runs to win, the visitor cruised home when Mominul Haque slashed Beau Webster to the backward point boundary.

Regular strikes

Bangladesh kept the pressure on throughout and didn't panic when Cameron Green (104) brought up his third Test century after lunch on day four.

Green was offered no real support from his teammates as the away side struck at regular intervals, with off-spinner Mehidy Hasan Miraz finishing with five for 66.

When Australia res-



Tormentor: Off-spinner Mehidy, right, hastened Australia's end with his 15th five-for. AP

umed on 161 for four, its hopes were pinned on Alex Carey and Green.

Carey lived dangerously

in the opening 30 minutes, twice edging seamer Hasan Mahmud through the vacant slips cordon for

SCOREBOARD

Bangladesh — 1st innings: 198.

Bangladesh — 1st innings: 426.

Australia — 2nd innings: Travis Head b Mahmud 17, Jake Weatherall b Mahmud 0, Marcus Labuschagne b Tajjil 31, Steve Smith c & b Mehidy 44, Cameron Green b Mahmud 104, Alex Carey c Litton b Mehidy 30, Beau Webster b Mehidy 5, Pat Cummins c Shadman b Mehidy 8, Mitchell Starc c Litton b Taskin 18, Nathan Lyon lbw b Mehidy 15, Josh Hazlewood (not out) 0; Extras (b-1, lb-6, nb-5): 12; Total (in 95.1 overs): 284.

Fall of wickets: 1-4, 2-37, 3-73, 4-122, 5-178, 6-193, 7-207, 8-250, 9-278.

boundaries. But on 30, Mehidy produced a beautiful ball, pitching in line and turning sharply to take Carey's outside edge to wicket-keeper Litton Das.

He struck again soon after, bowling Webster for five to leave Australia 193 for six and in deep trouble.

Bangladesh edged closer to a famous victory

Bangladesh bowling: Taskin 18-3-66-1, Mahmud 19-3-56-3, Ebadot 8-0-38-0, Tajjil 17-1-51-1, Mehidy 33.1-6-66-5.

Bangladesh — 2nd innings: Shadman Islam (not out) 25, Tanzid Hasan b Hazlewood 0, Mominul Haque (not out) 30; Extras (lb-2): 2; Total (for one wkt. in 14.2 overs): 57.

Fall of wicket: 1-4.

Australia bowling: Starc 4-0-15-0, Hazlewood 3-1-5-1, Lyon 5-0-23-0, Webster 2-2-0-10.

Bangladesh won by nine wickets.

Player of the Match: Mahmud.

Second Test: August 22 to 26, Mackay.

when Australia captain Pat Cummins pushed forward to a Mehidy delivery and got an inside edge to short leg, where Shadman Islam took a sharp chance.

Green and Mitchell Starc played sensibly to ensure Bangladesh had to bat again.

The visiting side got home in the 50th over.

Biggest win in Bangladesh's history, says proud Shanto

Agence France-Presse
DARWIN

Captain Najmul Hossain Shanto described Bangladesh's stunning nine-wicket win over Australia in the first Test here as the country's best result in its cricket history but warned that it cannot be a one-off.

"This is the biggest win so far for Bangladesh in any format," Shanto said. "We want to do something special in the future."

Fresh from a video call with Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, Shanto said that his side was determined to play just as well in the second Test, which starts on August 22 in Mackay. Leading into the game here, Bangladesh lost a Test to Zimbabwe by an innings and 85 runs and was thrashed by Cricket Australia XI in a warm-up game.



A triumph to savour: Bangladesh players on cloud nine. AFP

"We need to be consistent as a team," Shanto said. "We did not play well against Zimbabwe, but the confidence was still there because we had won against Pakistan in Bangladesh (in May). Before we came here, we had the belief that we will play good cricket."

Shanto warned that Australia would be eager to bounce back.

"As I said before this Test match, we wanted to play five days of good cricket, so nothing has changed. Going into the next Test, we need to follow the process, accept the challenges and enjoy those. Australia has a quality bowling attack, so we have to play good cricket again. As a bowling unit, we have to be disciplined again," the skipper added.

Sport

IN BRIEF



Sevilla snatches a win over Vallecano, Alaves beats Getafe

Sevilla scored from two second-half penalties as it came roaring back from a goal down to beat Rayo Vallecano 2-1 at home while Alaves hammered 10-man Getafe 3-0 as Spain's LaLiga went under way on Saturday evening.

The results: Alaves 3 (Tenaglia 73, Mariano 90+1, Rodriguez 90+4) bt Getafe 0; Sevilla 2 (Guridi 52-pen, Peque 90+7-pen) bt Rayo Vallecano 1 (Garcia 4).

Delhi routs Assam in junior women's National hockey

Delhi blanked Assam 6-0 in a Division-B (Pool-A) match of the 16th Indian Junior women's National championship in Pune on Sunday.

The results: Division-A: Pool-A: Jharkhand bt Chandigarh 6-0; Pool-B: Haryana bt Bengal 10-1; Pool-C: Uttar Pradesh bt Manipur 1-1; Pool-D: Chhattisgarh bt Himachal 6-4. Division-B: Pool-A: Delhi bt Assam 6-0; Pool-B: Uttarakhand bt Tamil Nadu 3-1.



Djokovic falls to Tirante in punishing conditions

Novak Djokovic suffered from punishing heat and humidity on Saturday but made a match of it before falling 2-6, 6-4, 6-4 to Thiago Tirante in what could be the Serb's last appearance at the ATP-World Cincinatti Masters. "It was a combination of the heat and humidity, all those things," he said. "Everything involved makes it worse." The Serb, who must now try to regroup before the US Open starts on August 30, admitted he might have played his last match in Cincy. "It looks like I won't be back, unfortunately to play here," he said. Tirante called the win the best of his career. "I managed the nerves of playing a legend like Novak. It was all so much pressure."

LIVE TELECAST

Badminton: World Championships, Sports 18.1, Sports 18-3 & BWF Official YouTube channel, 9 a.m. onwards

Sri Lanka vs India: First Test, Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LV, 9.45 a.m.

Hockey World Cup: (Women), SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 1 p.m. 2.30, 8.30 & 9.30 p.m.; (Men): SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 4 p.m. 5.30, India vs England, 6.30 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Tuesday)

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LV, 4 & 7 p.m.

LaLiga: FanCode, 12.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

We are relying on learnings from previous events, tells Praggnanandhaa's coach Suri

CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

After a bumpy start to the year, R. Praggnanandhaa has hit a purple patch. He made heads turn with a historic triumph in Norway Chess and stormed to victory in St. Louis Rapid & Blitz last week.

As Praggnanandhaa lets his moves do the talking on the board, the work he has been putting in with coach Vaibhav Suri seems to be paying off. "We did pay a little more attention to the opponents (in St. Louis) and tried to be in control. In the shorter formats, [holding the] nerves play a big role. I think that he was in far better control than in previous events," Suri said.

It is all about learning constantly and improving, Suri emphasised as his



Mentor and Mentee: Suri says Praggnanandhaa played with control in St. Louis. NORWAY CHESS

ward continues the good run in the ongoing Sinquefeld Cup in the USA – the 21-year-old put it across World Championship challenger Jorden van Foreest. "Preparation plays a huge part in classical chess, and we are relying on the learnings from previous events,"

With the Olympiad on the horizon and the in-form Praggnanandhaa expected to lead the Open team's

challenge, Suri felt that India had a strong squad, adding "there are huge expectations because we are the defending champions."

"The focus is going to be on trying to put the four best players on that given day and hope that they play their best. I am sure that Pragg, D. Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi, Nihal Sarin and Vidit Gujrathi will be preparing very seriously for the Olympiad."

Indian women's inexperience hurts them in a stalemate against China

The team dominates the opening 30 minutes but with eight debutants on show it is unable to stop its higher-ranked rival from fighting back

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

It was a game of two halves with India dominating the opening 30 minutes, before China turned the tables to assert why it is ranked five places above its Asian rival. India had eight World Cup debutants on show, who played with youthful zest but the inexperience ultimately hurt it in its 2-2 draw against China in its Women's World Cup Pool D opener here at the Wageningen Stadium on Sunday. India deservedly went 2-1 ahead at the break after goals from Navneet Kaur and Deepika. India's vertical approach, through the wings, troubled China's



Hemmed in: Deepika, who scored India's second goal, is crowded by the Chinese.

backline as Deepika and Lalremliam, in particular, looked dangerous with their dribbling and close control.

The opening goal came in the seventh minute when Neha fired in a pass to Navneet, which she deftly guided past several fe

into the bottom corner of the goal.

But a poor foul inside the circle by defender Shilpi Dabas, playing only her

Joon, Dhull hammer strikers, take Kings to DPL playoffs

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Siddharth Joon and Yash Dhull have combined brilliantly as an opening pair right from the start of the third edition of the Delhi Premier League. "It was no different on Sunday as Joon (76, 24b, 6x4, 8x6) and Dhull (69, 24b, 9x4, 4x6) stitched together a breathtaking stand of 140 in 7.3 overs to help Central Delhi Kings romp past North Delhi Strikers by eight wickets at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

Courtesy the emphatic win, Kings, sitting pretty on top with 14 points after eight matches, have become the first team to qualify for the playoffs.

The Central Delhi bowlers set up the win by restricting Strikers to 150 for nine after skipper Dhull chose to bowl. An all-round effort was in play, with Abhishek Yadav, Aatrey Tripathi, Tejas Baroka and Ganvish Khurana picking two scalps each. Strikers' subpar display with the bat was laid bare by the ease with which Joon and Dhull cruised to the target. In contrast to



Breathtaking stand: Joon, left, and Dhull added 140 for the opening wicket in just 7.3 overs.

Kings' position atop the standings, Strikers are in fifth spot with seven points after seven matches.

Warriors post win In the second game on Sunday, Outer Delhi Warriors outclassed Purani Dilli-6 by 21 runs. Yash Sharma's 86 helped Warriors post 219 for five. In reply, Purani Dilli scored 198 for six as Aman Chaudhary prised out four.

The results: North Delhi Strikers 150/9 in 20 overs (Bharat Sindhani 34, Abhishek Yadav 2/37, Aatrey Tripathi 2/43, Tejas Baroka 2/17, Ganvish Khurana 2/25) lost to Central Delhi Kings 151/2 in 9.3 overs (Siddharth Joon 76, Yash Dhull 69).

Outer Delhi Warriors 219/5 in 20 overs (Priyansh Arya 30, Yash Sharma 86, Akshay Saini 49 n.o., Harsh Tripathi 32, Digvesh Rathi 3/25) bt Purani Dilli-6 198/6 in 20 overs (Aryan Gaur 65, Samarth Sethi 42, Harsh Tripathi 3/20, Aman Chaudhary 4/38).

Rafique Sk. 53, 8. Calabasa (2) Ajay K 52.5 and 9. Coming Home (3) B. Nikhil 51.5.

1. FORTIS, 2. DUBAI TOUCH, 3. AUG. 17 RACES.

HIMAYAT SAGAR TROPHY (Div. II) (1,000m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 10 to 45 (Cat. III), 12.45: 1. Double Bubble (1) Kuldeep Sr. 61.5, 2. Linda (5) Akshay K 60.3, 3. Bold Beauty (4) Santosh Raj 59.5, 4. Ojas Maximum (2) A.A. Vikrant 58.5, 5. Swiss Girl (9) Abhay Singh 58.5, 6. Nyanya (10) Surya Prakash 57.7, 7. Cherish The Lady (7) Ajay K 55.5, 8. Fony Girl (9) Kuldeep Jr. 55.5, 8. Anemol (3) Kuldeep Jr. 54.9, 9. Atreya (8) D.S. Deora 51.5 and 10. Rate Of Interest (6) Arjun 50.1.

1. EK, 2. QUICK FOX 3, 3. TIGER RUBY

2. DONCASTER PLATE (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 10 to 45 (Cat. II), 1:15.1: 1. Classy Touch (6) Neera 54.5, 2. Como (2) Trevor 54.5, 3. Emergent (4) Akshay K 54.5, 4. Gacchamanaswin (10) M.S. Deora 54.5, 5. Havisa (5) Surya Prakash 54.5, 6. Love In Paris (1) R.S. Jodha 54.5, 7. Maggie (9) I. Chisty 54.5, 8. Mint (9) Mohit 54.5, 9. Queen Eternal (9) Ashad Ashar 54.5 and 10. Speedy Queen (7) P. Ajeeth K 54.5.

1. QUEEN ETERNAL, 2. COMO, 3. EMERGENT

3. B. MARISHESWARA RAO MEMORIAL TROPHY (Div. II) (1,000m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 10 to 45 (Cat. II), 1:15.1: 1. Dubai Touch (6) M.S. Deora 60.5, 2. Gloria (8) Akshay K 59.5, 3. N.R.I. Ultraworld (1) B.R. Kumar 59.4, 4. Fortis (4) Trevor 56.5, 5. Federer (5) P. Ajeeth K 55.5, 6. Perfect Light (7) Kuldeep Jr. 55.5, 7. Colt Pistol (9)

1. MARISHESWARA RAO MEMORIAL TROPHY (Div. II) (1,000m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 10 to 45 (Cat. II), 1:15.1: 1. Dubai Touch (6) M.S. Deora 60.5, 2. Gloria (8) Akshay K 59.5, 3. N.R.I. Ultraworld (1) B.R. Kumar 59.4, 4. Fortis (4) Trevor 56.5, 5. Federer (5) P. Ajeeth K 55.5, 6. Perfect Light (7) Kuldeep Jr. 55.5, 7. Colt Pistol (9)

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Rakshith Dave, 18, inherited victory in the premier Super Sport 301-400cc class following a 30-second penalty to Chiranth Vishwanath, who took the chequered flag first, as the first round of the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 2W-2026 concluded at the Madras International Circuit here on Sunday.

Earlier, 16-year-old Kabilish Rajini Krishnan, son of 11-time National champion Rajini Krishnan, scripted his maiden win in domestic competition by topping the Super Stock 301-400cc race.

Equally impressive was Ann Jennifer (Motul Sparks Racing), a former National woman champion, who won the Super Stock 165cc race. She thus completed a grand double, having won Race-1 on Saturday.

The results: Super Sport 301-400cc Open (Race-2): 1. R.S. Abdul Basim (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.275); 2. Amarnath K. Menon (MadRabbit Racing) (11:56.365); 3. P.M. Soorya (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.876).

Super Stock 301-400cc Open (Race-2): 1. R.S. Abdul Basim (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.275); 2. Amarnath K. Menon (MadRabbit Racing) (11:56.365); 3. P.M. Soorya (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.876).

Super Stock 165cc Intermediate (Race-2): 1. A.S. Ann Jennifer (Motul Sparks Racing) (12:51.378); 2. S. Anand Kumar (Ipone Yakusa Racing India) (12:52.927); 3. R.K. Anandhu (Veedol C Racing) (12:56.928).

Stock 301-400cc (Novice)

1. ASHOKA, 2. BRILLIANT LAD, 3. LUX AETERNA

7. BROWN JACK PLATE (1,400m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 10 to 45 (Cat. III), 1:45: 1. Glimmer Of Hope (7) Gaurav 62, 2. Aas Si (8) Antony Raj 61.5, 3. Decan Ranger (13) B.R. Kumar 61.5, 4. Desert Sultan (4) Mukesh K 61.5, 5. Fortune Art (12) Kuldeep Sr. 61.5, 6. Sucker Punch (4) A.A. Vikrant 61.5, 7. Golden Inizio (1) Shivam 60.5, 8. Midnight Beauty (6) Surya Prakash 60.5, 10. Rani Ruckus (11) G. Naresb 61, 11. Polaris (12) Arjun 59.5, 12. Musser (10) P. Ajeeth K 59.13, 13. Iconic Star (5) Rafique Sk. 51 and 14. Niloufer The Great (2) Kuldeep Jr. 50.

1. AOS SI, 2. GLIMMER OF HOPE, 3. FORTUNE ART

DAY'S FAVORITE: STAR OF OPERA

Jackpot: 4, 5, 6, 7 & 8; Mini Jackpot: 0/2, 3, 4 & 5, (10) 5, 6, 7 & 8, (11) 2 & 3, 4 & 5, (9) 4 & 5, (10) 6 & 7 & 8; Tanala: All races.

SHIVAM 53.5, 11. TOLKIE (6) NEERAL 53.5 and 12. VYASA (8) ASHAD ASHAR 53.5.

1. ALFONSINE, 2. MAYNE MAGIC, 3. PROKOFIEV

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On the podium: Rakshith, centre, is flanked by second-placed Rahil, left, and Mikail.

Mikail (MadRabbit Racing) (11:05.592); 2. V. Lokesh (Speed Up Racing) (12:22.085); 3. S. Venugopal (12:23.01).

Pro-Stock 200cc Open (Race-2): 1. R.S. Abdul Basim (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.275); 2. Amarnath K. Menon (MadRabbit Racing) (11:56.365); 3. P.M. Soorya (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.876).

Super Stock 301-400cc Open (Race-2): 1. R.S. Abdul Basim (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.275); 2. Amarnath K. Menon (MadRabbit Racing) (11:56.365); 3. P.M. Soorya (Chandra LGE Racing) (11:56.876).

Super Stock 165cc Intermediate (Race-2): 1. A.S. Ann Jennifer (Motul Sparks Racing) (12:51.378); 2. S. Anand Kumar (Ipone Yakusa Racing India) (12:52.927); 3. R.K. Anandhu (Veedol C Racing) (12:56.928).

Stock 301-400cc (Novice)

1. ASHOKA, 2. BRILLIANT LAD, 3. LUX AETERNA

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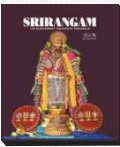
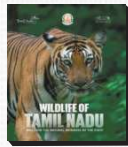
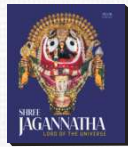


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THE HINDU EDUCATIONPLUS

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Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar

India's higher education system faces two challenges at once. A qualification earned in one part of the country should be recognised and respected elsewhere but the education offered must also be relevant to its students, languages, social setting, and surrounding economy. These aims may appear to pull in different directions. In practice, they can reinforce each other.

This balance is the essence of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which makes responsiveness to India's diversity and local conditions a guiding principle for curriculum, teaching, and policy. It calls for careful planning, joint monitoring, and collaboration between the Centre and the States, supports institutional autonomy and the expansion of programmes in local languages, and provides meaningful room for State priorities and local aspirations.

Guidelines

National frameworks provide broad guidelines to the institutions without imposing rigid prescriptions. For instance, the UGC framework leaves important academic decisions to institutional statutory bodies. Boards of Studies and Academic Councils can determine course lists and allocate credits across different programme structures.

Build the right connections

Strengthening institutional capacity, measuring outcomes reliably and using better regional data can create more opportunities for all learners



Thus, the frameworks focus on achieving the desired learning outcomes rather than imposing uniformity across every syllabus or subject combination. NEP 2020 seeks to remove rigid separations among arts, sciences and vocational learning while preserving disciplinary depth. New interdisciplinary

programmes can build confidence over time alongside established ones. Institutions are best placed to undertake this patient work. Recent commentary on regional higher-education needs has rightly emphasised that admission patterns must be understood in their regional context. This local perspective can

work within, rather than against, a national framework for academic mobility. Such data can reveal demand within a particular institution or region but they must be interpreted carefully.

A student's choice is also an exercise of agency. Career information should broaden that choice, not prescribe a single "cor-

rect" course based on short-term market trends. The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) 2023-24 records 4.50 crore students, compared with 3.42 crore in 2014-15. Over the same period, the gross enrolment ratio for the 18-23 age group rose from 23.7 to 30. These gains indicate an expanding social base. They are useful for building measures for flexibility, inclusion, and regional capacity.

Beyond course preferences, institutional reputation will continue to influence student decisions. Reputation may reflect teaching and research, but also history, location, alumni, programme range, and public visibility. A constructive approach is to widen the number of institutions that students and families can choose with confidence.

Student mobility

At the same time, local relevance should not confine a learner to the place of study. The National Credit Framework and the Academic Bank of Credits seek to make academic, vocational and experiential learning recognisable and portable across institutions and States. Institutions must ensure that credits are accurately recorded, transferred, and redeemed to enable students to complete their programmes promptly. When these arrangements work well, portability and place-based learning support student mobility.

A related question con-

cerns the relationship between curriculum and employment. Degrees cannot be designed only around immediate job openings because economies and occupations change. Higher education must build knowledge, judgement, communication, creativity, and the capacity to learn. It should also give students opportunities to apply those capabilities in professional, social, and community settings. NEP 2020's emphasis on multi-disciplinary learning, internships, vocational exposure and local opportunity mapping brings these purposes together.

The UGC's guidance enables institutions to develop internship projects suited to their academic programmes and the surrounding economic environment. Its university-industry framework encourages regional clusters, Industry Relations Cells and engagement with micro, small, and medium enterprises. Apprenticeship-embedded degree programmes and Professors of Practice provide further channels for professional participation. AICTE's model curricula and applied-learning initiatives similarly connect technical education with projects, internships and emerging fields. These mechanisms respect the academic role of institutions while bringing employers and practitioners into appropriate parts of the learning process.

Accordingly, we should continue to build a stron-

ger evidence base linking education to opportunity. From graduating students, institutes could collect information on employment, further study, entrepreneurship, location, wages, and the use of skills at suitable intervals after graduation, while respecting privacy issues. They should also present student-facing programme information, such as curriculum, costs, eligibility, accreditation, internships, completion, and possible pathways, in clear language, without making predictive promises. States and regional skills centres could bring together official labour data, apprenticeship information, industry evidence and institutional records. This can help students and families, institutions, employers and States make better decisions.

Ultimately, India needs a connected education system in which qualifications are recognised across regions. Institutions should adapt to local needs, while students should be free to choose their learning pathways. We should continue to strengthen institutional capacity, measure outcomes reliably and use better regional data. NEP 2020 provides us with a path to develop national frameworks that focus on local relevance to create better opportunities for all learners.

Views are personal

The writer is the Chairman of the Review Committee for NEP 2020 and Chairman, BOE, IIM-Calcutta.

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Indian hopes rest on Sindhu and Satwik-Chirag combine

The country has won at least one medal in the last 11 editions of the mega event; Ayush has his task cut out against Shi

WORLD CSHIPS

Uthra Ganesan

NEW DELHI

The badminton World championships starting here on Monday will be as much a test of India's growth in the sport as a show of its organisational abilities both on and off the court.

The last time India hosted the marquee event in 2009, it had a grand total of one medal in the tournament's history. Since then, the country has not gone without one in the 11 editions starting 2011.

P.V. Sindhu, with five medals including the lone Indian gold under her belt, carries the hopes yet again. The ninth seed will begin her campaign



Leaving no stone unturned: Chirag and Satwik would be keen to add to their medal tally. SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR

against world No. 141 Sofia Nobel of Ireland. The road to the top will be anything but easy for the 31-year-old in her 10th Worlds. The 2019 gold was also her last medal in the competition. However, Sindhu has found form in recent times, clinching the Japan

pan's Nozomi Okuhara). I was very hard on myself. These moments made me stronger," Sindhu said on Sunday.

Defending champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan will be looking to become the first women's singles player to win four golds, going past Spain's Carolina Marin.

Also hoping to put their recent injury woes behind and add to their collection would be Asian Games gold medalists Satwiksai-raj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty. The top Indian men's doubles pair has got a bye in the first round.

On Monday, Indian youngster Ayush Shetty takes on defending champion and top seed Shi Yuqi in the opening round. The 21-year-old is eyeing a first win in four meetings

against the Chinese.

Lakshya Sen, attempting to become the first Indian man to win two medals, will begin against Collins Filimon of Austria on Tuesday. He is likely to run into former champion Thai Kunlavut Vitidsarn in the pre-quarterfinals.

India's Ashvith Surya and Amrutha Pramuthesh have been promoted to the mixed doubles main draw.

Indians in action (Monday):
Men: Singles: Ayush Shetty vs. Shi Yuqi (Chn).
Doubles: M.R. Arjun & Hartharan Amsakarun vs. Scott Guildie & Paul Reynolds (Ire).
Women: Singles: P.V. Sindhu vs. Sofia Nobel (Ire).
Doubles: Treasa Jolly & Gayatri Gopichand vs. Paula Lopez & Lucia Rodriguez (Esp); Kavipriya Selvam & Simran Singh vs. Nikal Carulla & Carmen Maria Jimenez (Esp).

Ever-hungry Sindhu targets record sixth Worlds medal

Devvanshi Bihani

NEW DELHI

Five-time World championships medalist P.V. Sindhu will look for a record-breaking sixth prize as she begins her campaign here on Monday. A half dozen medals will make her the first women's singles player to achieve the feat in the tournament.

Fresh from ending a long wait for a title at the Japan Open, Sindhu said the triumph had given her

the confidence for the World championships. "It has been quite good, physically and mentally. I have been able to see the changes in terms of my game and my movement," she said.

One thing that has remained throughout her career, she said, is her "hunger towards the game."

"I know it is in me and I can still do it."

But the game has evolved, with women's singles becoming more demanding. "Women's sin-

gles used to be more attacking and fast-paced. Now it is more about long rallies, patience and staying on court for a longer period," she said.

Experience, she added, has helped her deal with conditions that can force players to alter their style.

"I'm much more experienced now in terms of how to deal with different conditions on court.

"Sometimes there is drift, and sometimes you cannot control the shuttle



Sindhu. SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR

the way you want.

"You have to change accordingly and make things

convenient for yourself."

The home setting brings added expectations, but the pressure that comes with playing a high-stakes match is nothing new to her.

"I have played a lot of first-round matches where I had butterflies and there is a lot of pressure... at the same time, there is nothing to lose. I just want to give my best because I have trained hard and I have worked hard in my training session".

SC Delhi turns the tables on Raengdai, meets East Bengal

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau

Former champion East Bengal FC edged past Indian Army FT I-O in the second quarterfinal of the 135th Durand Cup at the Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata on Sunday.

The Kolkata outfit will face Sporting Club Delhi in the semifinal at the same venue on Wednesday. The latter had defeated FC Raengdai 5-1 in the first last-eight clash.

Vishnu strikes

P.V. Vishnu scored in the 39th minute, heading home a well-delivered cross from Christopher Ikonomidis to give East Bengal the lead.

The host dominated the first half and created several chances, but Army goalkeeper Bhabindra Malla Thakuri made a series of impressive saves.

East Bengal, which recently qualified for AFC Champions League Two, struggled to convert its opportunities after the break. However, its defence held firm.

At the Birsa Munda Stadium in Ranchi, SC Delhi produced a remarkable second-half comeback and netted five goals to turn the tables on debutant Raengdai.

Chongtham Kishan Singh gave the Noney-based Manipur side the lead with a spectacular long-range strike in the ninth minute.

Inspired change

After half-time, SC Delhi coach Tomasz Tchorz introduced India under-23

forward Joseph Sunny.

The move paid off as Sunny scored twice within 10 minutes to put Delhi 2-1 ahead by the 67th minute.

Rodriguinho, Juan Sebastian Pena and Augustine Lalrochana added a goal each as Delhi roared back in style.

The results (quarterfinals):

At Ranchi: Sporting Club Delhi 5 (Joseph Sunny 57, 67, Rodriguinho 82, Juan Sebastian Pena 90+3, Augustine Lalrochana 90+8) bt FC Raengdai 1 (Chongtham Kishan Singh 9).

At Kolkata: East Bengal FC 1 (P.V. Vishnu 39) bt Indian Army FT I-O.

Monday's matches: At Kolkata: Mohun Bagan Super Giant vs. Jamshedpur FC (4 p.m.); **At Shillong:** Shillong Lajong FC vs. NorthEast United FC (7 p.m.).

APPOINTMENT

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3.	Assistant Professor	English	01	01 - OPEN
4.	Assistant Professor	Economics	01	01 - OPEN
5.	Assistant Professor	History	01	01 - OPEN
6.	Assistant Professor	Political Science	01	01 - OPEN
7.	Assistant Professor	Sociology	01	01 - OPEN
8.	Librarian	-	01	01 - OPEN

- The above posts are open to all, however candidates from any category can apply for the post.
- Candidates having knowledge of Marathi will be preferred.
- Qualification, Pay Scales and other requirement are as prescribed by the UGC Notification dated 18th July, 2018, Government of Maharashtra Resolution No. Misc-2018/C.R.56/18/UNI-1, dated 8th March, 2019 and University circular No. TAAS/CT/ICD/2018-19/1241, dated 26th March, 2019 and revised from time to time" The Government Resolution & Circular are available on the website mu.ac.in
- Applicants who are already employed must send their application through proper channel.
- Applicants are required to account for breaks, if any in their academic career.
- Application with full details should reach the CHAIRMAN, K.L.E. Society's, KLE COLLEGE OF LAW, 4th Floor, Plot No. 29, Sector-01, Kalamboli, Nav Mumbai, Panvel - 410 218 within 15 days from the date of publication of this advertisement. This is University approved advertisement.

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The Olympics is always the biggest stage

Robles has high hopes about Spain's future in table tennis, credits UTT for the evolution of the sport in India and shares the recipe for staying in the top 100 for more than a decade



BUTTERFLY UTT

INTERVIEW

Alvaro Robles

Amol Karhadkar

For more than a decade, Alvaro Robles has been a regular presence on the international table tennis circuit. The Spanish left-hander, who has reached a career-high No. 28 in the world, has spent nearly 10 years inside the top 100 and is now a familiar face in the Ultimate Table Tennis, having featured in six of the seven editions.

Robles' journey, however, began with an unlikely idol: Timo Boll. As a teenager in Spain, he watched videos of the German great and began copying his game before eventually moving to Germany to train alongside some of the world's best.

That decision, he says, shaped not only his table tennis but also his personality.

Now a father of two, Robles continues to juggle the demands of a professional career with family life while trying to earn another shot at the Olympics.

In an interaction with *The Hindu*, he spoke about Boll, his move to Germany, the evolution of Spanish table tennis, longevity in the sport, UTT's impact on Indian table tennis and his desire to feature in another Olympics. Excerpts:

You have spoken about Boll being one of your idols. How did that fascination begin?

I started watching him when I was 16 or 17. He was in his prime and I watched so many of his matches. I took a lot of motivation from his game. I think my style is quite similar to his.

Was there a particular moment that got you hooked to his style?

What I remember most is that when I was 16 or 17, we started getting access to computers and I watched the first videos on YouTube. I was very impressed. I started copying him in practice and tried to take every skill from him as a left-hander. As you said, it was natural for many lefties to copy Boll.

You then moved to Germany. Did you get an opportunity to interact with him?

Not very often, but a few times. I played against him and practised with him. It was a privilege to share those moments with somebody I really admired. I could never beat him – he was so good – but I managed to have some close matches. I was very happy about that.

How much did moving to Germany transform your career?

It had a huge impact on my career and table tennis. I got to know the best players in the world and learnt more about training systems, how other players think and what mentality is required to reach the top.

How difficult was it as a teenager to take that decision?

It was a difficult choice. When you decide to move, you don't know the consequences or what you will face. But it was a beautiful journey to discover. If I look back, I would do it again. I met people from all around the world... different countries and cultures. I am really happy to have experienced that kind of life.

Was it tough for your family to understand why you wanted to move to Germany?

In Spain, there was not much of a tradition for table tennis. My parents supported me, but I am not sure they knew exactly what kind of future I would have. I am grateful for their support and the freedom they gave me because that allowed me to develop my career, my personality and my character. I discovered so much about myself during that journey.

How much has Spanish table tennis changed over the last two decades?

It has developed a lot. I think we have been very successful in improving the medium level of players. Now we have around 20 players competing at a very similar level. They are not yet at the top level, but many are between 100 and 300 in the world and can compete really well.

The next step is obviously to have more players inside the top 100. But even at the base, we have some amazing under-13, under-15 and under-17 players achieving unbelievable international results.

If a Spanish teenager came to you today saying he wanted to make a career in table tennis, what would you tell him?

First, it is very important to understand the background of each player – where they come from, which club they belong to, how old they are and what they want to achieve. Everyone is individual and different. That is the first thing I would observe before giving any advice. I would like to know the background of each player so I can help them better.

You have spent almost a decade in the world's top 100. How demanding is that consistency?

It is very demanding. For 10 years I have been inside the top 100, and it costs a lot. In my case, the secret is consistency in the work. I thought about my practice, physical condition and performance every day. I was worried about improving every day

and maybe that is why I have remained around the top 50. Now I am No. 67, but before the Olympics, I reached No. 28, which was great for my career. I keep thinking every day about how I can return to my best shape. I hope I can remain at this level for another 10 years.

Players are now extending their careers well into their late 30s and 40s. How has that become possible?

A few things have changed. There are now many opportunities to continue playing WTT events and league matches. There are great leagues where players can earn an income. To perform for many years, there is much more information about taking care of yourself – nutrition, physical preparation and psychology. Earlier, many players didn't have access to so much information.

Because of this, we feel better with our bodies, play with fewer injuries and continue believing that we can play at 38, 40 or 42. Then it comes down to your mental approach, motivation, circumstances, family and how long you want to keep travelling. Look at Robert Gardos, who is 47 and still performing extremely well. That is impressive, but it is also because he takes great care of himself.

How would you compare the support structure in Spain with countries such as Germany or Sweden, or India?

Support is not only about money. For me, support means having a structure of coaches and people who help develop the sport – physical trainers, analysts, physiotherapists and people guiding players towards their maximum potential.

Sometimes we are confused. Support is not simply 'I give you

money and then you do what you want.' Support is creating a structure that helps a group reach its potential. That is what is improving now.

How difficult is it to balance travelling for seven months a year with family life?

It is difficult. I have travelled abroad for six or seven months a year, and it is hard when you know your family is at home. My children are young and they miss me.

We try to manage the logistics so they can come to some tournaments. My daughter came to the World Championships in Doha last year and they came to a Contender in Macedonia. That gives me energy because being away from home for so many weeks is difficult. Bringing them with me and having them around gives me motivation to keep trying for my best results.

How has fatherhood changed the approach to your career?

Totally. Even though I thought I would manage it one way, everything changed because the feelings are different. Suddenly, you have to face things you are not prepared for and manage them with your wife and family.

I think that it has been the biggest work I have had to do in recent years – more than table tennis: learning how to handle family life with professional life.

You have been part of UTT for six seasons. How have you seen the league evolve?

Quite well. The idea was to create a league where foreign players could bring experience to Indian table tennis. Now you see how much Indian table tennis has grown. It is crazy.

If you compare 2018 with 2026, you can now see how many Indian players are in the top 100, top 50 and top 40. Youngsters play as if they have 20 years of experience.

Earlier, you didn't see that. Now there are many of them.

That has come from the investment and effort of the federation and the people who wanted to create the league. It is very impressive. You see youngsters such as Syndrela Das, who was watching from the stands when she was 11 or 12, now playing against players like Manika Batra and even beating them. That comes from a country's big effort to develop a sport.

What do you enjoy doing away from table tennis?

I love sport. I like playing tennis, padel and football. All my hobbies are related to sport. Going out with my wife when the kids are not with us is also something I enjoy – going on holiday after many months of hard work. That is how I switch off and recharge.

You have won a World championship doubles silver and a European mixed doubles gold. What remains the biggest target?

The European championship gold in mixed doubles is a great achievement because, at the end, it is a gold medal. It is very special to me. But the Olympics is always the biggest stage. Everything I am doing is aimed at getting that experience one more time. I know winning an Olympic medal is something really, really difficult... on another level.

But I try to find my best version and keep the opportunity open. You never know. I will keep fighting to be there and give my best version one more time.



SCIENCE

Scientists find why an enervating disorder affects only Eurasians

The Nizam's Institute of Medical Sciences in Hyderabad, diagnoses one case of Friedrich's ataxia every month on average — and almost all of these individuals come from consanguineous marriages, according to medical geneticist Ashwin Dalal

D.P. Kasbekar

Friedrich's ataxia, or FRDA, is a genetic disorder that progressively damages the nerves and the heart.

The affected individuals typically begin to show symptoms between the ages of 5 and 15. They become unsteady and their coordination is impaired. Their speech slows down and slurs. Swallowing becomes difficult. Hearing and vision deteriorates. They feel fatigued, lose sensation, first in the arms and legs, then in the trunk and other parts of the body, and the spine curves to one side. Eventually, most patients die relatively young, of heart disease. There is no cure.

According to Ashwin Dalal, a medical geneticist at the Nizam's Institute of Medical Sciences in Hyderabad, the institute diagnoses one case of FRDA every month on average — and almost all of these individuals come from consanguineous marriages. That is, marriages between relatives, such as uncles and nieces, or between cousins. Many Indian communities practise consanguinity — and it greatly increases the risk of genetic diseases that are otherwise rare. Friedrich's ataxia is one such disease.

Curiously, so far, FRDA has not been reported in people from sub-Saharan Africa, North America, and China, Japan, and Southeast Asia. For a long time, scientists have only found it in individuals of European, North African, West Asian, and South Asian descent.

A new study from researchers at the University of Oklahoma Health Sciences Center in the U.S. has finally cracked the puzzle. Their findings were reported in June 9 in the journal *Human Molecular Genetics*.

Inefficient powerhouses

FRDA is caused when a gene called *FXN* becomes mutated.

The *FXN* gene codes for a protein called frataxin. Frataxin is essential for mitochondria, which are our cells' powerhouses. The chemical ATP, which is the cell's energy currency, is mostly in the mitochondria. Nerve, spinal cord, brain, and heart muscle cells use a lot of energy. When their frataxin levels become abnormally low, the mitochondria produce ATP less effectively and also accumulate toxic by-products. This renders the cell dysfunctional, leading to the symptoms of FRDA.

The most common disease-causing mutations occur in a part of the *FXN* gene called the intron. A mutation takes the form of modifying the number of times a particular sequence of bases is repeated in the intron. Normal variants of the *FXN* gene contain 5-11 or 12-33 repeats. They're called the short normal and long normal



For a long time, scientists found FRDA in individuals of European, North African, West Asian, and South Asian descent. GETTY IMAGES (REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE)

variants. The short-normal variant is common in Europe and South Asia (85-90% of the population), sub-Saharan Africa (90%), and East Asia (over 99%). The long-normal variants are absent in East Asia and make up most of the rest in sub-Saharan Africa and in Europe and South Asia.

However, the DNA sequences of people with Friedrich's ataxia revealed their *FXN* alleles variants had 100-1,500 repeats. The researchers called them expanded variants.

The short-normal and long-normal variants have an open structure in the chromosome that allows cells to make frataxin as needed. However, the expanded variants forced the chromosome to assume a closed shape that reduced frataxin expression.

Individuals who develop Friedrich's ataxia carry two copies of the expanded variant, one from each parent. A person with only one copy is called a carrier. Even though they themselves won't have the disease, carriers can pass their defective introns to their children.

Fortunately, genetic tests can find out if a person is a carrier and whether they passed their extended variant to their children.

From mutation to disease

The researchers also found that 95% of the expanded variants of the intron originally came from just two long-normal variants. Specifically, they reported that at two times in history, a long-normal variant mutated to an extended variant,

These findings will help scientists understand what makes the two protomutations different from other long-normal variants; this answer in turn will help find ways to prevent or at least slow down the genetic changes

both times in Eurasia. We don't know why these events happened nor why only long-normal variants mutated this way. We also don't know why this never happened in sub-Saharan Africa. On the other hand, the absence of long-normal variants in East Asian populations could explain why these problematic mutations didn't arise there.

These originator mutations, which the researchers called protomutations, didn't straightaway lead to Friedrich's ataxia. Instead, they slowly but steadily changed into pre-mutations — where the number of repeats was abnormally high but not enough to significantly impair frataxin expression.

The non-disease-causing but still abnormal pre-mutations turned into an extended variant in a sudden burst of repeat expansion in a single or few parent-to-child transmissions.

Recall that people with Friedrich's ataxia die earlier. So over time, the extended variants disappear from the population. People with protomutations and pre-mutations on the other hand did not present that risk. As a result, they

acted as 'reservoirs' in the population that steadily replenished the depleting extended variants over time.

Taken together, the patchy distribution of protomutations can explain why Friedrich's ataxia occurs only in some populations.

The protomutations arose only a few times and only in populations with a sufficient number of the long-normal variants.

Ancient DNA

Finally, by analysing DNA from the skeletal remains of individuals who lived in ancient times, the researchers also found both the two protomutations were present in Europe and Western Asia at least 9,000 years ago. However, they were not seen in the Neanderthals and Denisovans.

In a statement, research team leader Sanjay Bidichandani credited "the longstanding tradition in the human genetics community of freely sharing DNA sequence data" to be "crucial to accurately track the presence of susceptibility to Friedrich's ataxia from prehistoric humans to a wide variety of extant populations".

These findings will help scientists understand what makes the two protomutations different from other long-normal variants that don't turn into pre-mutations. This answer in turn will help find ways to prevent or at least slow down the genetic changes.

(D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist. kasbekardp@yahoo.co.in)

THE GIST

So far, Friedrich's ataxia has not been reported in people from sub-Saharan Africa, North America, and China, Japan, and Southeast Asia

A new study from researchers at the University of Oklahoma Health Sciences Center found that Friedrich's ataxia is caused when a gene called *FXN* becomes mutated

The study found that patchy distribution of originator mutations, called protomutations, can explain why Friedrich's ataxia occurs only in some populations

BIG SHOT



Adult and immature blue-footed boobies rest on rocks near the entrance to the Panama Canal as seabirds native to the cold, nutrient-rich waters off Peru and Chile appear outside their usual range, while El Niño warms the eastern Pacific and disrupts marine food supplies, off the coast of Panama City on August 5. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Hara mangrove forests

Vasudevan Mukunth

The Hara forests are a vital ecological treasure of the Persian Gulf. Spanning the Strait of Hormuz, these mangrove forests consist mainly of grey mangrove trees (*Avicennia marina*), which have a special filtration system in their roots that allows them to thrive in saline conditions. The same roots also protect the coast against erosion and are voluminous carbon sinks, sequestering significantly more carbon than terrestrial forests.

The forests are a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve and serve as an important nursery for marine life as they shelter shrimp, crabs, and numerous fish species that sustain the region's fisheries. Up from the water's edge, the Hara forests' canopy is also a major migratory hub for birds like the great stone-curlew and various herons. The mangroves are the backbone of the sustainable tourism programmes of Qeshm, an Iranian island in the Persian Gulf, and draw visitors to their labyrinthine waterways.

Protecting these forests is crucial for the lives and livelihoods of Qeshm's local communities and for efforts to preserve the Gulf's natural heritage. Environmentalists have said losing them would trigger a catastrophic collapse of the local food chain and coastal defences.



A satellite image shows Qeshm Island following an oil spill at sea, off the coast of Iran, on August 10, 2026. REUTERS

Recent satellite images have revealed a major environmental threat to just these forests: an oil spill off Qeshm's southern coast. Experts have identified the source to be a bulk carrier named Minoan Pioneer, which has been leaking heavy fuel oil after being struck by a projectile. The slick stretches 160 km long, with dark liquid already washing ashore. The ongoing West Asia conflict is also hindering cleanup efforts, leaving the mangroves at great risk of devastation.

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